



CITY: Pg 5

Outreach: CM Gupta goes grassroots for Budget inputs



NATION: Pg 9

BJP unveils 88 candidates for Assam polls



FILM: Pg 14

Alia recalls her first day on 'Kapoor & Sons'

FUEL PRICES SURGE; BRENT CRUDE HITS \$118, UP OVER 60% SINCE FEBRUARY 28

Iran steps up attacks on oil, gas facilities in Gulf after Israeli strike on key gas field

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Iran intensified its attacks on oil and gas facilities around the Gulf on Thursday, dramatically raising the stakes in a war that is sending shock waves through the global economy.

The strikes, in retaliation for an Israeli attack on a key Iranian gas field, sent fuel prices soaring and risked drawing Iran's Arab neighbours directly into the conflict.

Tehran's targeting of energy production further stressed global supply already under pressure because of Iran's stranglehold on the Strait of Hormuz, a strategic waterway through which a fifth of the world's oil is transported.

Tehran warned that it its energy facilities were attacked, "subsequent attacks against your energy infrastructure and that of your allies will not stop until their complete destruction, and our response will be far more severe than" last night's attacks."



A fire and plume of smoke rise after, according to authorities, debris from an intercepted Iranian drone struck an oil facility in Fujairah, United Arab Emirates

KEY POINTS

- » Iran threatens sustained destruction of energy infrastructure if attacks continue
- » Strait of Hormuz disruption fears intensify; handles one-fifth of global oil flows
- » Vessel set ablaze off UAE; another ship damaged near Qatar
- » Iranian drone hits Saudi Red Sea refinery, disrupting alternative export routes
- » Saudi Arabia intercepts six drones; Yanbu refinery damage under assessment
- » Qatar's Ras Laffan LNG facility hit; "extensive" damage reported, production halted

KUWAIT REFINERIES MINA AL-AHMADI, MINA ABDULLAH HIT; FIRES REPORTED, NO INJURIES

Shell said damage assessment was underway at the facility.

Qatar, a key source of natural gas for world markets, said firefighters put out a blaze at the Ras Laffan LNG facility after it was hit by Iranian missiles. Production had already been halted there after earlier attacks. The state-owned QatarEnergy said the fire had caused "extensive" damage, and energy giant Shell said it was assessing it.

Ras Laffan is the largest liquefied natural gas export facility in the world, according to QatarEnergy. Damage to the facility could delay Qatar's ability to get supplies to the market even after the war ends.

A drone attack on Kuwait's Mina Al-Ahmadi refinery sparked a fire but caused no injuries, the state-run KUNA news agency reported. The refinery is one of the biggest in the Middle East. Shortly after, a drone attack set ablaze the nearby Mina Abdullah refinery, officials said.

Continued on P6

India condemns strikes on West Asian gas hubs, calls for immediate halt

PM Modi speaks to leaders of Jordan, France, Oman, Malaysia

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: As fresh attacks on West Asian gas hubs triggered global concerns and threatens an energy crisis, India on Thursday said the strikes are "unacceptable and need to cease" even as Prime Minister Narendra Modi reached out to top leaders of Oman, Jordan, France and Malaysia, emphasising the urgency to restore peace in the volatile region.

Following his phone conversation with Jordan's King Abdullah II, PM Modi said the attacks on energy infrastructure in West Asia are "condemnable and can lead to avoidable escalation".

New Delhi described the attacks on the gas infrastructure as "deeply disturbing" and that assaults will only serve to further destabilise an already uncertain energy market globally.

An Israeli attack on Iran's strategic gas fields of South Pars on Wednesday resulted in an intense Iranian retaliation on key energy infrastructure in a number of Gulf nations including Qatar's LNG (liquefied natural gas) hub of Ras Laffan. Qatar accounts for



TAKEAWAYS

- » Modi tells Jordan's King attacks are condemnable and risk avoidable escalation
- » MEA says attacks worsen already uncertain global energy scenario
- » Modi, Oman's Sultan discuss ensuring free passage through Strait of Hormuz
- » Modi, Macron agree on urgent de-escalation and return to dialogue
- » India, Malaysia reaffirm commitment to diplomacy for early peace restoration

nearly 40 per cent of India's LNG requirement.

"India had previously called for the avoidance of targeting

Continued on P6

LPG bookings close to normal, but situation continues to be worrisome

NEW DELHI: Domestic LPG refill bookings are nearing pre-conflict levels, indicating gradual stabilisation, though supply constraints for commercial users persist amid disruptions linked to the West Asia crisis. Daily bookings, which averaged 55 lakh before February 28 strikes, had surged to 87.7 lakh on March 13 due to panic buying. They eased

to 56-57 lakh by March 18, said Sujata Sharma, noting, "Panic booking is coming down." India lost access to nearly 60 per cent of LPG imports after the Strait of Hormuz shutdown. Domestic output has risen over 40 per cent, with uninterrupted household supplies, while commercial users receive only 20 per cent of demand.

See P6

Stock market mayhem wipes out Rs 12.87 lakh cr

Sensex crashes 2,500 points on oil shock

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Investor wealth took a sharp hit on Thursday as Indian equity markets tumbled amid rising global tensions, wiping out Rs 12.87 lakh crore in a single session. The sell-off followed a surge in crude oil prices linked to escalating attacks on energy infrastructure in West Asia, deepening concerns over global supply disruptions.

The 30-share BSE Sensex snapped its three-day gain-

ing streak, plunging 2,496.89 points or 3.26 per cent to close at 74,207.24, its lowest level since April 7, 2025. During intra-day trade, the index had fallen as much as 2,753.18 points or 3.58 per cent to 73,950.95, marking its steepest one-day decline since June 2024. The broader market rout dragged the total market capitalisation of BSE-listed firms down by Rs 12,87,273.89 crore to Rs 4,26,13,557.95 crore, equivalent to USD 4.61 trillion.

Continued on P6

RS 65,946 CR MARKET VALUE WIPED OUT

RBI assures no governance lapses at HDFC Bank after Chairman's exit

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: India's largest private sector lender by market value, HDFC Bank, faced a sharp market reaction and intense scrutiny on Thursday after its part-time chairman Atanu Chakraborty stepped down citing ethical concerns, even as the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the bank's leadership sought to reassure stakeholders that there were no governance lapses or financial weaknesses.

Within hours of the resigna-

tor described HDFC Bank as a Domestic Systemically Important Bank with strong financials, a professionally managed board and adequate liquidity, adding that its overall position remains satisfactory.

Chakraborty's sudden exit, effective March 18, 2026, marks the first instance of a part-time chairman leaving the bank mid-term.

nation becoming public, the RBI issued a statement asserting that it had "no material concerns on record" regarding the bank's conduct or governance. The regula-

tor described HDFC Bank as a Domestic Systemically Important Bank with strong financials, a professionally managed board and adequate liquidity, adding that its overall position remains satisfactory.

Chakraborty's sudden exit, effective March 18, 2026, marks the first instance of a part-time chairman leaving the bank mid-term.

His resignation comes just weeks before the close of the financial year 2025-26 and nearly three

Continued on P6

MANDATES DISCLOSURE ACROSS OIL, GAS CHAIN

Govt classifies energy data as national security matter



MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at tightening oversight of the energy sector, the Union government has classified petroleum and natural gas data as a matter of national security, requiring companies across the value chain to submit detailed operational information on a regular basis.

The directive, issued through the Petroleum and Natural Gas (Furnishing of Information) Order, 2026 by the Oil Ministry, mandates refiners, LNG importers, pipeline operators, city gas distributors and petrochemical firms to share granular data with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC). The March 18 gazette notification applies to both public and private entities and, in some cases, requires daily reporting.

Companies must disclose information on production, imports, exports, stock positions, storage, transportation and consumption patterns. The order states that data may be submitted in daily, weekly

THE OBLIGATION TO FURNISH INFORMATION UNDER THIS ORDER SHALL APPLY NOTWITHSTANDING ANYTHING CONTAINED IN ANY CONTRACT...

or monthly formats through designated electronic platforms. It also makes clear that reporting obligations override any existing confidentiality clauses.

"The obligation to furnish information under this order shall apply notwithstanding anything contained in any contract... and no entity shall refuse to furnish information... on the ground that such information is commercially sensitive or proprietary," the notification said.

The decision follows disruptions in global energy flows triggered by the ongoing conflict in the Middle East, which has effectively shut the Strait of Hormuz,

Continued on P6

NO EMBARGO ON RELIGIOUS GATHERINGS AT PRIVATE SPACES, COURT RULES

HC affirms right to pray on private premises under Art 25

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Allahabad High Court has ruled that the right to conduct prayers or religious gatherings within private premises is protected under Article 25 of the Constitution, stressing that such activities cannot be restricted based on faith or denomination. The observation came in an order dated March 16 while the court was hearing a petition concerning limits imposed on offering namaz during Ramzan at a site in Sambhal. The bench of Justices Atul Sreedharan and Siddharth Nandan said any objections by individuals or groups to prayers on private property must be addressed by the state, which is also obligated to ensure protection for both the place of worship and the worshippers.

The court reiterated that



"there can be no impediment or embargo" on religious functions conducted within private premises, regardless of the religion of the individual. It clarified that Article 25 guarantees every person the equal right to profess, practice and propagate their faith, subject only to public order, morality and health. At the same time, it warned that actions or

CLOSER LOOK

- » Case linked to Ramzan prayer restrictions in Sambhal
- » Court says no embargo on religious functions in private spaces
- » Applies equally across all religions and denominations
- » State must act against objections to private prayers

speech that could disturb public order or incite tensions between religious groups fall outside constitutional protection and may invite criminal action.

The case arose from a petition filed by Sambhal resident Munazir Khan, who alleged that authorities had restricted the number of worshippers to 20 during Ramzan at a premises he

- » Protection must be ensured for worshippers and premises
- » Article 25 subject only to public order, morality and health
- » Incitement or actions disturbing harmony not protected
- » Petitioner alleged limit of 20 worshippers imposed
- » State cited law and order concerns for restriction

described as a mosque. The state defended the restriction by citing concerns over law and order. However, the court rejected this reasoning, stating earlier that it is the duty of the administration to uphold the rule of law in all circumstances. It had also remarked that officials such as the district magistrate and superintendent of police should consider resigna-

tion or transfer if they felt unable to manage the situation without imposing such limits.

After examining photographs submitted as part of a supplementary affidavit, the bench noted that the structure in question was not a mosque at present. Nevertheless, it acknowledged that namaz had been offered there previously and held that there should be no obstruction to continuing prayers at the site.

The court also referred to its earlier ruling in the Maranatha Full Gospel Ministries case, reaffirming that no prior permission from authorities is required to hold prayer meetings on private premises. It directed the state to remain mindful of this position.

Addressing broader constitutional principles, the bench stated that its interpretation of Article 25 should not be seen as granting any special status

Continued on P6

RBI explores new avenues for Russia-held rupee balances

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India is exploring ways to expand the use of Indian rupees accumulated by Russian trade partners, a senior official said on Thursday, as both countries continue efforts to deepen local currency trade.

N Senthil Kumar, chief general manager in the RBI's Foreign Exchange Department, said the central bank is working on options to channel these rupee balances into productive use. "We are working on providing various avenues for using the INR, which is accumulated here by the Russian counterparts, to use it either for settling their imports or making capital investments in India," he said at a Russia-India forum in Mumbai.

The move comes after years of focus on settling bilateral trade in local currencies to reduce dependence on the US dollar. In 2024, the RBI also allowed surplus balances to be invested in government securities.

Kumar pointed to a degree of "inertia" among exporters and importers in adopting local currency transactions. He said greater trust is needed to boost usage and increase transaction volumes.

Continued on P6

Bowing before Lord Ram same as paying homage to Mother India

President Murmu

In today's paper

INTERNATIONAL

THAPA RESIGNS AS NC CHIEF 2

CITY

RAINS, GUSTY WINDS SWEEP DELHI 5

EDIT

DOMINANCE MYTH 7

NATION

THAROOR SIDES WITH GOVT 9

BUSINESS

ICICI BANK GETS ₹769 CR GST NOTICE 10

SPORT

7-STAR BARCA ROLL ON 12

India appoints Vikram Doraiswami as ambassador to China

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Seasoned diplomat Vikram Doraiswami was appointed India's new ambassador to China on Thursday, as New Delhi and Beijing continue efforts to restore relations strained by a prolonged military standoff in eastern Ladakh.

Doraiswami, a 1992-batch Indian Foreign Service officer, is currently serving as India's High Commissioner to the United Kingdom. He will replace Pradeep Kumar Rawat and is expected to assume his new role shortly, the Ministry of External Affairs said.

His appointment comes at a time when both countries have been working to stabilise ties after the 2020 Galwan Valley clash pushed bilateral relations to their lowest point in decades. The military standoff, which lasted over four years, effectively concluded in October 2024.

An alumnus of Delhi University with a master's degree in history, Doraiswami briefly worked as a journalist before joining the foreign service. After completing his training in New Delhi between 1992 and 1993, he was posted to Hong Kong in May 1994 as Third Secretary. During this period, he obtained a diploma in Chinese from the New Asia Yalen-Asia Language School. He later served in Beijing from September 1996 for four years.

Over the course of his career, Doraiswami has held several key positions, including Deputy Chief of Protocol at the



Continued on P6

WILL US DEPLOY TROOPS TO SEIZE URANIUM?

Trump faces his most difficult Iran war decision

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump is facing perhaps the most daunting question of the war with Iran, one that could define his time in office: Will he put US troops on the ground in Iran to secure some 970 pounds of enriched uranium that Tehran could potentially use to build nuclear weapons?

Trump has offered shifting reasons for launching the war, but he has been consistent in articulating that a primary objective in joining Israel in the military action is ensuring that Iran will "never have a nuclear weapon".

The president has been more circumspect about how far he's willing to go to follow through on his pledge to destroy Iran's weapons programme once and for all, including seizing or destroying the near-bomb-grade nuclear material that Iran possesses.

Much of it is believed to be buried under the rubble of a mountain facility pummeled in US bombings Trump ordered last June that he had claimed "obliterated" Tehran's nuclear programme.

It's a risky, complicated project that many nuclear experts say cannot be done without a sizable deployment of US troops into Iran, a dan-



Key Points

- » Trump has offered shifting reasons for launching the war
- » The president has been more circumspect about how far he's willing to go to follow through on his pledge
- » Stockpile could allow Iran to build as many as 10 nuclear bombs

US President Donald Trump

gerous and politically fraught operation for the Republican president, who has vowed not to entangle the US in the sort of extended and bloody Middle East conflicts that still loom large on America's psyche.

At the same time, lawmakers and experts remain concerned that if Iran hardliners emerge from the fighting, they'll be more motivated than ever to build nuclear weapons as they look to deter

the US and Israel from future military action, a dynamic that makes taking control of Iran's enriched uranium even more critical.

That stockpile could allow Iran to build as many as 10 nuclear bombs, should it decide to weaponise its programme.

Some lawmakers, like Sen. Richard Blumenthal, D-Conn., say they remain deeply fearful that the president has put the nation on a path that

will require putting troops inside Iran for what he called Trump's confused and chaotic objectives.

"Some of the objectives that he continues to espouse simply cannot be achieved without a physical presence there -- securing the uranium cannot be done without a physical presence," said Blumenthal, a member of the Senate Armed Services Committee.

AGENCIES

Over 1,000 killed in Israel- Hezbollah war: Lebanon

DUBAI: Israeli strikes against the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon have displaced more than 1 million people — roughly 20 per cent of the population — according to the Lebanese government, which says more than 1,000 people have been killed.

Israel said it has killed more than 500 Hezbollah militants. The Iran-backed Hezbollah entered the wider Iran war by firing rockets at Israel.

That led to the heavy Israeli bombardment of southern Lebanon.

AGENCIES

Pentagon seeks \$200 billion in additional funding for Iran war

DUBAI: The Pentagon is seeking \$200 billion in additional funds for the Iran war, a sizable amount that is certain to be met with questions from Congress, which would need to approve any new money.

The department sent the request to the White House, according to a senior administration official, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the private information. Asked about the figure at a press conference Thursday, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth did not directly confirm the

Trump warned that the US would retaliate and 'massively blow up the entirety' of Iran's gas field if it continues

amount, saying it could change. "It takes money to kill bad guys," Hegseth said.

But he said "we're going back to Congress and our folks

there to ensure that we're properly funded."

It's an extraordinarily high number and comes on top of extra funding the Defense Department already received last year in President Donald Trump's big tax cuts bill. Such a request would need to be approved by Congress, and it is not at all clear such spending would have political support.

Congress has been bracing for a new spending request but it is not clear the White House has transmitted the request for consideration.

AGENCIES

Japan PM meets Trump under pressure on Hormuz

WASHINGTON: The meeting that Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi will have at the White House on Thursday originally seemed like a prime opportunity to have President Donald Trump's ear before he embarked on a trip to China.

But now, the war in Iran and Trump's unsuccessful call for Japan and other nations to help protect the Strait of Hormuz means the China trip has been delayed and Takaichi may be likely to get an earful.

Trump has repeatedly complained on camera and online that US allies, including Japan, have rejected his request to help safeguard the critical waterway for oil and gas transport.

"In fact, speaking as



US Prez Donald Trump (left) and Japan's PM Sanae Takaichi

FILE PIC

President of the United States of America, by far the Most Powerful Country Anywhere in the World, WE DO NOT NEED THE HELP OF ANYONE!"

Trump exclaimed on Truth Social after his initial call for help was rebuffed.

The prime minister acknowledged before she left Japan that she expects her

meeting with Trump will be "very difficult." She is scheduled to meet with the Republican president on Thursday morning at the White House and return in the evening to join him for dinner.

During their meeting, Takaichi and Trump are expected to announce a \$40 billion nuclear reactor deal, according to a White House official, who was not authorized to speak publicly and spoke on the condition of anonymity to share details before the announcement.

Under the deal, US-based GE Vernova Inc. and Japan-based Hitachi Ltd. will build advanced small modular reactors in Tennessee and Alabama, the official said.

AGENCIES

Ukraine peace talks on pause amid Iran war, says Kremlin

MOSCOW: The Kremlin said on Thursday that talks between Washington, Moscow and Kyiv on ending the war in Ukraine were on "situational pause" following the start of the Iran war.

U.S. President Donald Trump vowed to end the Ukraine war on his return to the White House but has said efforts to resolve the conflict have been one of his biggest disappointments.

The Izvestia newspaper said in a front-page story that the Kremlin had confirmed a pause in talks on Ukraine and that war in the Middle East could push Kyiv towards compromise.

"This is a situational pause,



Municipal workers clear the rubble of residential building damaged after a Russian drone strike in Odesa on Thursday

AP/PTI

for obvious reasons," Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov told reporters when asked about the Izvestia report.

Peskov said that as soon as "our American part-

ners" could pay more attention to Ukrainian affairs, Moscow hoped that the pause could end and that a new round of talks could take place.

AGENCIES

FESTIVE FERVOR



People board an overcrowded passenger train to reach their homes on the eve of Eid al-Fitr holidays, marking the end of the Islamic holy fasting month of Ramadan, at a railway station in Lahore on Thursday.

AP/PTI

Nepal police arrest six Indians over fake travel lottery scam

KATHMANDU: Nepal police on Thursday arrested seven people, including six Indians, for running a fake travel lottery scam.

Those arrested include Nepali national Bibek Regmi, 26, a resident of Saptari district currently residing in Gathaghar, Thimi of Bhaktapur district and Indian nationals Hussain Sayed, 39, Sajid Omar Sayed, 44, Mohamad Imran, 34, Mirkhalid Hussain, 33, Rajak Mohamad, 40, and Samada Giri, 42, all from Telangana, Hyderabad.

They are currently residing in the Mahalaxmi Municipality of Lalitpur

district, according to the Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Office.

Those arrested were cheating hundreds of Nepalese through a fake lottery scam under which the victims were told they had won a lottery to visit various destinations in Asia, Europe and Africa from Sheertel Holidays Pvt. Ltd.

They cheated 328 Nepalese citizens and collected 27.65 million NPR in the pretext of issuing cheap holiday packages through lottery, said the police.

They also hired 30 Nepalese staff to run their lottery racket, police added.

AGENCIES

NEPAL POLITICS

Thapa resigns as NC chief

KATHMANDU: Nepali Congress President Gagan Thapa has submitted his resignation from the post after the party's defeat in the recently held general elections, a media report said on Thursday.

The House of Representatives elections held on March 5 elected a 275-member Lower House known as the Pratinidhi Sabha.

The Nepali Congress



NC Chief Gagan Thapa

(NC) secured 38 seats in the polls, despite its slogan -- "This time, over 100 seats".

Thapa, 49, who was

projected as the NC's prime ministerial candidate, also lost from Dhanusha-4 constituency to Amaresh Singh of the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP).

Thapa submitted his resignation to NC Vice President Bishwa Prakash Sharma shortly after a date for the party Central Working Committee meeting was fixed, The Kathmandu Post reported.

AGENCIES

China, US reach new consensus in trade talks in Paris

BEIJING: China on Thursday said "new points of consensus" have been reached in its current trade talks with the US ahead of President Donald Trump's planned visit to Beijing, which was postponed due to the escalating conflict in West Asia.

China and the US have agreed to continue making good use of their economic and trade consultation mechanism to strengthen dialogue and communication,

Key Points

- » The two parties agreed to explore the establishment of working mechanisms to expand economic and

trade cooperation

- » Trump previously scheduled to visit Beijing, the first by a US president since 2017, from Mar 31 to April 2

China's Commerce Ministry said on Thursday.

The ministry's spokesperson, He Yongqian, while responding

to a question on the recent China-US economic and trade talks in Paris, said both sides engaged in candid, in-depth and constructive

consultations on issues of mutual interest, including tariff arrangements, promoting bilateral trade and investment, and maintaining the existing consensus from earlier consultations.

"Some new points of consensus were reached, and both sides agreed to maintain consultations," He said at a media briefing here.

The two parties also agreed to explore the establishment of

working mechanisms to expand economic and trade cooperation, continue to make good use of the China-US economic and trade consultation mechanism, strengthen dialogue and communication, properly manage differences, and expand practical cooperation to advance the sustained and steady growth of bilateral economic and trade relations, the spokesperson said.

AGENCIES

CHILDREN WISH TO SPEND EID AT HOME

In Lebanon, war, displacement mar run-up to Eid al-Fitr holiday for many

BEIRUT: Normally, Lilian Jamaan would have been shopping for clothes for her daughter and buying meat and sweets in preparation for the Islamic holiday of Eid al-Fitr that marks the end of Ramadan.

But now, "there's no joy for Eid or for Ramadan or for anything," Jamaan said by phone from a school-turned-shelter in the Lebanese city of Sidon, where she's been displaced with her family.

"Everything is difficult," she said. As the Islamic holy month of Ramadan draws to an end and Muslims worldwide prepare for the typically joyous holiday of Eid al-Fitr, Lebanon has crossed a grim milestone. Israel's strikes have displaced more than 1 million people in the country, according to the Lebanese government.

Lebanon's health ministry said 968 people were killed by the Israeli strikes in the country since the renewal of hostilities between Israel and the Lebanese militant group Hezbollah.

The Iran-backed Hezbollah entered the wider Iran war by firing rockets at Israel. That led to the heavy Israeli bombardment of southern Lebanon and Beirut's southern suburbs, driving many



Displaced boys who fled Israeli strikes from south Lebanon, plays with toy planes at a school playground turned into a shelter, in Sidon

AP/PTI

from their homes. "A lot of the kids that I at least spoke to, their biggest wish was to just spend Eid at home," said Basma Alloush, a spokesperson for the International Rescue Committee.

"Eid is a time where all families come together, people celebrate with their relatives, and it usually brings a lot of peace and joy to families. ... It could be that many of them just spend Eid in shelters, in displacement." The suffering has played out during Ramadan with scenes of people forced to flee their

homes, reduced to sleeping in tents on the streets or in their cars.

Some secured coveted spots in schools and other locations turned into shelters or stayed with relatives; many others scrambled to find makeshift arrangements. Only about 130,000 are in shelters.

For Jamaan, the harsh conditions in displacement meant she could no longer observe many aspects of Ramadan — a time for fasting, increased worship and usually festive communal gatherings with loved ones.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

PROBE OF HONG KONG'S DEADLIEST FIRE IN DECADES BEGINS HEARINGS

HONG KONG: An independent committee investigating the cause of Hong Kong's deadliest fire in decades heard accounts on Thursday about how a series of failures contributed to the 2025 blaze that engulfed seven buildings and killed 168 people as hearings in the case got underway. Former residents and relatives of the dead have been waiting for answers since November 2025, when the fire shattered the close-knit community of Wang Fuk Court, which housed thousands of people in the suburban district of Tai Po. In his opening remarks, committee lead lawyer Victor Dawes said the most likely cause of the fire was cigarettes that lit other materials on fire on a platform in an air shaft between two low-level units in Wang Cheong House.

US ENVOY IN SEA LANES, PORTS SECURITY TALKS WITH SRI LANKA

COLOMBO: The US Special Representative for South and Central Asia Sergio Gor and Sri Lanka President Anura Kumara Dissanayake on Thursday discussed strengthening of bilateral relations and the island nation's position on the West Asia crisis. The US Special envoys' visit to Sri Lanka comes at a time when Sri Lanka came to be embroiled in the joint US-Israeli war against Iran since February 28. The US Special envoy will also travel to Maldives after Sri Lanka in the 5-day visit for high-level engagements focused on advancing cooperation in the Indian Ocean Region.

पत्रांक-534 / बेतिया

जल संसाधन विभाग

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय

जल निस्सरण प्रमंडल, बेतिया

ee.drainagedivision.bettiah@gmail.com

अल्पकालीन निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या -07/2025_26

(केवल ई-टेंडर पद्धति के अनुसार वेबसाइट <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> पर

कार्य का विवरण -

सूच सं०	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कति राशि (लाख रु० में)	अग्रधन की राशि (रु० में) (अर्ध लाख अथवा फिक्स्ड / निगुअ माद में मुयतेव)	परिमाण-विषय का मूल्य (अप्रत्यर्णीय) (रु० में) (रुयवा) (केवल ऑन लाईन माद में मुयतेव रु० में)	बेल्दुर्न को देय बिड प्रोसेसिंग की (अप्रत्यर्णीय) (रु० में) (केवल ऑन लाईन माद में मुयतेव रु० में)	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि
01	A.E. work on left bank of Gandak river near village Siva Mangalpur. (Agenda No. 244/39/2026)	123.09	246200.00	10000.00	3540.00	15.05.2026

2. निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना निर्गत करने की तिथि : दिनांक: 18.03.2026

3. निविदा कागजात डाउनलोड एवं अपलोड करने की तिथि एवं समय : दिनांक: 28.03.2026 के पूर्वान 10:30 बजे से दिनांक-04.04.2026 के 03:00 बजे अपराहन तक की अवधि (सिर्फ वेबसाइट <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> पर)

4. प्री-बिड मीटिंग का तिथि एवं समय : दिनांक: 30.03.2026, 03:00 बजे अपराहन में, मुख्य अभियंता, बाढ़ निर्यंत्रण एवं जल निस्सरण, जल संसाधन विभाग, मुजफ्फरपुर।

5. तकनीकी बिड खोलने की तिथि एवं समय : दिनांक : 06.04.2026 समय 03:30 बजे अपराहन। (सिर्फ वेबसाइट <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> पर)

6. वित्तीय बिड खोलने की तिथि एवं समय : सक्षम पदाधिकारी द्वारा बाद में घोषित की जायेगी (सिर्फ वेबसाइट <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> पर)

7. निविदा खोलने का स्थान : <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> पर

8. निविदा की वेबसाइट अवधि (निविदा : प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि से) : 120 दिन

9. विज्ञापनदाता का पदनाम एवं पता : कार्यपालक अभियंता, कार्यालय जल निस्सरण प्रमंडल, बेतिया।

विशेष जानकारी प्राप्त करने हेतु वेबसाइट <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> एवं वेबसाइट <https://wrd.fmscwrdbihar.gov.in> & www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar पर देखा जा सकता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता

जल निस्सरण प्रमंडल, बेतिया

PR-026778 (WRD) 2025-26

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से स्या।



Towards
VIKSIT BHARAT
Through Simplified
TAXATION LAW

Income Tax Act, 2025
Applicable from 1st April, 2026

“Today the goal of the country is Viksit Bharat, Sashakt Bharat! We cannot stop until this dream of a developed India is fulfilled.”
Shri Narendra Modi
Hon'ble Prime Minister



**PRARAMBH
2026**

Roll out of the Nationwide Awareness Campaign
on the Income Tax Act 2025

Inauguration by

Smt. Nirmala Sitharaman

Hon'ble Union Minister of Finance and Corporate Affairs

at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi | 20th March 2026

Stakeholders

Income Tax Department

Industrial Bodies/ Trade Associations
/ ICAI / ICMAI / Technical Experts

Taxpayers

Key Highlights of the Campaign



Public Outreach

Over 320 outreach sessions
nation wide from April to
June, 2026



Educational Content

Educational content on the new
Act, Rules & Forms. Inclusive of
Guidance notes, brochures
and tutorials.



Thematic Sessions

Regular expert led
interactions in physical
sessions and on
social media handles



Public Engagement

Nationwide quiz on Income
Tax Act, 2025 on
Mygov portal,
Exciting prizes for winners!

Special launch of the 'Income Tax Website, 2.0'



LIVE

STREAMING ON YOUTUBE CHANNEL



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PIL FLAGS RISK OF COMMUNAL TENSION IN AREA

Ensure peaceful, dignified Eid in Uttam Nagar: HC tells police

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Thursday directed the city police and administration to ensure a conducive atmosphere for peaceful and dignified observance of Eid in Uttam Nagar where a 26-year-old man was killed in a clash on Holi.

A bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said the police bandobast in the area should be such that it instils a sense of safety and security in all.

The bench directed the authorities to ensure that no one plays any mischief that has the potential to create any “untoward situation”.

It clarified that the police arrangements in the area shall continue till the upcoming festival of Ram Navami.

The order was passed on a PIL filed by a civil rights group, the Association for Protection of Civil Rights, which approached the Delhi High Court on Wednesday to prevent “imminent



Officers stand guard at barricades ahead of Eid al-Fitr, at Uttam Nagar

communal violence” on Eid in Uttam Nagar.

The petition came up for hearing after a petitioner’s counsel mentioned the matter before the Chief Justice’s bench for an urgent listing during the day. After hearing the parties, the court said Eid is a festival of all authorities to ensure that on such a “pious occasion”, public life is not disrupted by any untoward incident of vandalism or hooligan-

ism by any individual or any section of society.

It observed that the apprehensions in the petition arose from the incident of the death of a youth in the area on March 4, and therefore, the police must be “extra cautious” and ensure that “all sections of society maintain restraint considering the past incident”.

“We thus direct the police and civil administration of the area to take all required action, permissible under law,

HIGHLIGHTS

- » ‘Police bandobast to be made should be such as will instil a sense of safety, security in all’
- » ‘The authority shall also ensure that no one from any section of the society is permitted to play any kind of mischief, having the potential of creating any untoward situation’: Court order

creating any untoward situation,” it further said.

The court added that if, upon assessment of the situation, a need is felt to strengthen the arrangements, such measures shall be forthwith taken by the authorities.

“The situation as described in the petition not only calls upon authorities to be at constant strict vigil but it also calls upon members of different sections of society to maintain restraint and conduct themselves in a manner which may promote peace and harmony and not cause any situation which may turn ugly,” the bench further said.

The court issued notice on the PIL and listed it for hearing on April 6.

Delhi Police told the court that heavy deployment, round-the-clock vigil and preventive steps are in place in Uttam Nagar. Over 50 inflammatory posts were removed, 8,000 people verified, while the PIL alleged hate speech and inaction.

Two held for targeting tourists in Nabi Karim pick-pocketing racket

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested two alleged thieves, including a teenager, for targeting tourists in a calculated pickpocketing scheme in Nabi Karim. The accused, Jatin (19) and Jitender Kumar (25), both residents of the area, were held following a complaint lodged at Nabi Karim police station.

The case came to light after a Navi Mumbai resident reported that his wallet, containing cash and important documents, was stolen on March 13 while he was visiting the locality with his wife.

Police registered an FIR under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and launched an investigation.

A team analysed CCTV footage from the area and identified a distraction-based modus operandi, where one accused engaged the victim in conversation while the other swiftly stole the wallet from his back pocket.

Both accused, who work as labourers, were later apprehended from Nabi Karim. Police recovered the stolen wallet along with Rs 1,600 in cash. Officials described them as “budding criminals” and said further investigation is underway to determine their involvement in similar incidents.

BJP, AAP leaders scuffle in Palam over response to fire that killed 9

NEW DELHI: A confrontation over a fatal blaze in southwest Delhi’s Palam escalated into a physical scuffle between BJP MLA Kuldeep Solanki and AAP Delhi unit president Saurabh Bharadwaj on Thursday.

The clash broke out a day after a fire claimed the lives of nine people, with leaders from both parties trading charges over alleged lapses in the emergency response.

The incident occurred when representatives from both sides visited the area where nine members of a family, including a 70-year-old woman and her three granddaughters, died on Wednesday.

According to police, the altercation was triggered by



a heated exchange over an alleged delay in deployment of hydraulic cranes during the firefighting operation.

“The argument escalated into a brief scuffle, with supporters from both sides raising slogans against each other,” a senior officer with Delhi Police said. The situation was brought under control after police intervention, the officer said, adding

that additional force has been deployed in the area to maintain law and order.

Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav on Thursday wrote to L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu, seeking a probe into the Palam fire incident that killed nine people. He said the tragedy could have been prevented with timely rescue operations and alleged delays in emergency response.

Citing data, Yadav said 4,652 people died in fire incidents between 2016 and 2025, with 24 deaths reported in 2026 so far. He also flagged manpower and equipment shortages in the fire department and urged measures to curb such incidents. **MP05T**

Sultanpuri: Gunshots fired in air, FIR lodged

NEW DELHI: A group of men allegedly fired shots in the air after vandalising a momo stall in outer Delhi’s Sultanpuri area, reportedly due to an ongoing feud between two groups, police said on Thursday.

A PCR call regarding the incident was received at the Sultanpuri police station around 10.44 pm on Wednesday, prompting a police team to rush to the spot.

The stall owner, Irfan (29), a resident of Sultanpuri, told police that he was present at his stall when a few people sud-

denly arrived, began throwing food items, including momos, and created a disturbance. “One of them then fired a shot in the air before all of them fled from the spot,” a senior police officer said.

Police recovered an empty cartridge, confirming firearm use. Preliminary inquiry points to a long-standing feud between two groups, recently escalating on social media. An FIR has been registered under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and teams are searching for the absconding accused. **MP05T**

Debt-ridden man burgles own house, arrested with jewellery

During the probe, the team found no signs of forced entry, which raised suspicion: Cops

he had gone to Ghaziabad with his family, and when he returned, he found it ransacked, with gold jewellery worth around Rs 20 lakh and some cash missing.

“During the investigation, the team found no signs of forced entry, which raised suspicion,” a senior officer said.

During interrogation, the complainant’s son confessed that he had suffered financial losses in stock market trading and was under pressure to repay debts. “He hatched a plan with his friend and provided him with a duplicate key. After confirming the house was vacant on the day of the incident, Vishal entered the house using the key,” the officer said.

Both accused were arrested within hours, and stolen gold jewellery worth around Rs 20 lakh and Rs 37,000 in cash were recovered, the police said. **MP05T**

Man nabbed for youth’s murder in Jahangirpuri

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has arrested a 22-year-old man for the alleged murder of a youth in a revenge attack. The accused, Firdaus alias Chumma (22), a resident of Jahangir Puri, was wanted in an FIR registered on March 4 at the local police station for fatally shooting Rehmatullah alias Bhola.

Police said Firdaus had been absconding since the incident along with his associates. He was apprehended on March 18 near Bhalaswa Lake by a Crime Branch team acting on a tip-off. A raiding party was

formed, and he was identified by an informer before being arrested without incident.

During interrogation, the accused reportedly confessed to his role in the crime, stating that he and an associate opened fire on the victim due to personal enmity.

He had been frequently changing locations to evade arrest, police said.

Police said Firdaus has a criminal background, including a prior theft case, and has been booked under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act. **MP05T**

Excise case: HC extends deadline for Kejriwal & Sisodia in ED plea

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Wednesday granted time till April 2 to former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, his deputy Manish Sisodia and 21 others to respond to a plea by the Enforcement Directorate to expunge “unwarranted” remarks made against it by the trial court while discharging them in the liquor policy case.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma expressed displeasure over the request for more time by the lawyers appearing for Kejriwal and other accused, and said it would fix a date for final hearing in the matter during the next hearing on April 2.

“I don’t know why you are not filing a reply. You should have filed a reply if you think you really needed to file a reply. They are only saying judge should not have written something that he has written.”

“The court had discharged Arvind Kejriwal and Manish Sisodia, calling the case speculative, lacking evidence”

“By second (of April), you file your reply. Then we will fix a date for final hearing,” the judge said.

The Enforcement Directorate’s counsel said there was no need to file replies to its petition and that this was an attempt to delay the case.

Additional Solicitor General S V Raju, appearing for ED, contended that the agency’s petition has no impact on the accused, as the challenge was limited to the trial court judge’s observations against the agency when it discharged Kejriwal, Sisodia and others in the CBI case.

The counsel for one of the accused said a brief reply was necessary and time was needed for it as the discharge order was 600 pages long.

Justice Sharma remarked that the ED’s case has nothing to do with all 600 pages.

“Here is a prosecuting agency which has stated that the judge exceeded jurisdiction. I told them even I make such observations. I need to decide it but you said I need to file a reply. Now you say 600 pages have to be read,” the judge observed.

The Enforcement Directorate said the trial court’s remarks were extraneous, as it was neither a party nor heard, and sought their removal to avoid prejudice.

The court had discharged Arvind Kejriwal and Manish Sisodia, calling the case speculative, lacking evidence, and warning that misuse of the PMLA could threaten personal liberty.



after a fire engulfed a residential building with commercial use on lower floors.

The incident exposed multiple risk factors, including high fire load, limited ventilation and access constraints in congested areas.

The officer said such mixed-use buildings are particularly vulnerable, as storage of flammable materials such as clothes and cosmetics can intensify fires within minutes, leaving little time for evacuation.

Seasonal patterns also emerge from the data.

In 2025, fire calls peaked during April (2,991 calls) and October (1,867 calls), suggesting a link with weather conditions and increased electrical usage.

The officer further said that after winter, when electrical appliances often remain unused, restarting them without proper inspection can increase the risk of short circuits due to accumulated dust or wear and tear.

Authorities have stressed the need for stricter enforcement of fire safety norms, especially in residential buildings and commercial establishments operating without clearances.

Ghaziabad: Astrologer jumps from 13th floor; mother’s decomposed body found at home

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: A 42-year-old astrologer died by suicide after jumping from the 13th floor of a high-rise in Mahaganpuram Society along NH-9 on Thursday afternoon. When police reached his residence, they discovered the decomposed body of his 70-year-old mother inside the flat.

The incident occurred around 1:45 pm in Vinayak Tower. Residents reported hearing a loud crash after a fibre sheet near the shaft broke. On reaching the spot, they found the man lying critically injured in a pool of blood. He was identified as Rajveer Chawla, a resident of a ground-



When police reached to inform the family, they found the door open and discovered his mother, lying on a bed with her face exposed. The body appeared to be 2 to 3 days old

floor flat in the same tower. He was rushed to a nearby hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

When police went to inform his family, they found the flat door open. Inside, his mother, Satnam Kaur, was lying on a bed, covered with a blanket with only her face visible. The room emitted a foul smell, and the body appeared to be two to three days old. No vis-

ible injury marks were found.

ACP Kavinagar Suryabali Maurya said preliminary investigation suggests financial distress may have driven Chawla to take the extreme step. He reportedly ran a YouTube channel related to astrology but was struggling to earn. Police are also probing his strained personal life, as his wife and son had been living separately due to marital discord.

Police suspect the mother may have died naturally, though foul play has not been ruled out. Another angle being examined is whether a dispute led to her death before Chawla died by suicide.

No suicide note was recovered. Both bodies have been sent for post-mortem examination, and further clarity is expected after reports and questioning of family members.

LPG CRUNCH

Mounting losses for Delhi eateries amid reduced working hours, curtailed menu

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than a week after commercial LPG supply crunch hit the capital, restaurants and street food vendors are still struggling to resume full operations, with many operating for reduced working hours and serving a curtailed menu, while also reporting sharp losses.

Operators said while there has been some improvement, access to commercial LPG cylinders remains inconsistent, forcing eateries to cut down menus, reduce working hours and limit cooking to bulk preparation.

“Over the past 10 days, business has taken a severe hit. Earlier, our average daily billing across branches was around Rs 3 lakh, but it has now dropped drastically to just about Rs



25,000 to Rs 30,000,” a representative of the Tadka Rani restaurant chain said.

He added that they are currently serving barely 20 per cent of their menu, with portions standardised and only bulk preparations being made, while working hours have also been impacted due to operational constraints.

“Managing operations has become extremely difficult, especially with electrical equipment heating up quickly and limited availability of resources. We are trying to gradually

resume some items depending on how the situation improves,” the representative said.

He said initially, the outlets had to be shut down completely, and even now, operations remain highly restricted, with losses mounting every day.

The disruption in commercial LPG supply follows a recent government revision in priority allocation of domestically produced natural gas amid broader energy security concerns in the wake of deepening conflict in West Asia.

“Most restaurants are now functioning in a restricted manner, cooking only limited items in bulk, and not continuously”

“Most restaurants are now functioning in a restricted manner, cooking only limited items in bulk, and not continuously. It is no longer possible to operate at full capacity,” a Shahdara-based restaurant owner said.

He further said during Navratri, football is expected to dip further, worsening already reduced earnings, and many are incurring significant losses.

“While the situation has shown slight improvement, disruptions persist. Many restaurants are still strug-

gling to function normally,” National Restaurant Association of India (NRAI) Treasurer Manpreet Singh said.

He said several establishments are partially open, some operating only on certain days depending on availability of cylinders, while others remain shut intermittently, with uncertainty looming on the entire sector.

“This week, we could open our restaurant for only two days. For the rest of the week, we had to remain shut due to lack of resources,” an east Delhi restaurant owner said.

Amid LPG shortage, vendors said they are forced to shut stalls or use unsafe alternatives. Many struggle to access commercial cylinders, risking penalties for using domestic ones, while rising costs and erratic supply hit livelihoods.

‘PUBLIC PARTICIPATION IS THE BIGGEST STRENGTH OF A DEVELOPED DELHI’

OUTREACH: CM Gupta goes grassroots for Budget inputs

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at shaping an inclusive and people-centric Budget 2026, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday held extensive pre-budget consultations with gig workers, farmers, rural representatives and labour groups at the Delhi Secretariat.

The consultations, held in separate sessions, saw participants raising key concerns related to employment conditions, social security, rural infrastructure and agricultural reforms. The Chief Minister interacted directly with attendees and assured them that their suggestions would be incorporated into the budget planning process. “Public participation is the biggest strength of a developed Delhi,” she said.

Gig workers highlighted the need for improved working conditions, including safe parking spaces, rest facilities and better access to public amenities. They also demanded expansion of EV infrastructure and subsidies, especially for women drivers. Concerns over social security dominated the dis-



cussions, with calls for linking workers to provident fund systems, health schemes and recognition as “employees” instead of “partners.”

Farmers and rural representatives focused on strengthening agricultural infrastructure, seeking better irrigation systems, improved rural roads and reforms in mandi operations. They also raised demands for

subsidies, fair compensation mechanisms and revision of circle rates for agricultural land. Access to Kisan Credit Cards, easier loans and effective crop insurance implementation were also highlighted.

Labour groups emphasised welfare measures such as timely wages, housing, healthcare and improved working conditions. They called for labour offices

in every district, expansion of schemes like ESIC and PPF, and the formation of a Labour Welfare Board.

Reassuring all stakeholders, Gupta said the government is committed to addressing their concerns. “We will address their concerns and ensure they receive adequate facilities,” she said, adding that agriculture, rural development and worker

HIGHLIGHTS

» The Chief Minister interacted directly with attendees and assured them that their suggestions would be incorporated into the budget planning process

» ‘Public participation is the biggest strength of a developed Delhi’

» Gig workers highlighted the need for improved working conditions, including safe parking spaces, rest facilities...

welfare will receive special focus in the upcoming budget.

Labour and Development Minister Kapil Mishra termed the consultations a step towards inclusive governance. “Farmers and rural areas were neglected under previous governments, but under Chief Minister Rekha Gupta’s leadership, significant work is being done for villages, the poor and farmers,” he said.

CM Rekha offers prayers as Chaitra Navratri begins

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Marking the beginning of Chaitra Navratri with devotion and cultural fervour, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited the iconic Jhandewalan Temple on Thursday, offering prayers to Goddess Durga and later joining a vibrant devotional event that highlighted a growing youth-driven spiritual trend in the Capital.

On the first day of the nine-day festival, the Chief Minister performed special rituals at the temple and prayed for the well-being of Delhi’s residents. She sought divine blessings for “happiness, prosperity and well-being of the people of Delhi,” reflecting the spiritual significance of the occasion.

Addressing devotees, Gupta underlined the cultural importance of Navratri, stating, “Navratri symbolises India’s rich cultural heritage, devotion and strength.” She added that the festival “inspires people with positive energy, inner strength and a spirit of service towards society,” expressing hope that Goddess Durga’s blessings bring peace and prosperity to every household in the city.

Following the prayer, the Chief Minister attended a devotional music event titled ‘Bhajan Clubbing’, organised near the temple premises. The event featured soulful bhajans



CM Rekha Gupta at Jhandewalan Temple

“Navratri symbolises India’s rich cultural heritage, devotion and strength” — CM Rekha Gupta

preserves traditions but also strengthens “unity, peace and harmony in society.”

Highlighting a notable trend, the Chief Minister pointed to the increasing participation of young people in such events. “The growing interest among youth in Bhajan Clubbing is both encouraging and inspiring,” she said, adding that such initiatives are helping connect the younger generation with India’s cultural and spiritual roots. Reaffirming the government’s stance, Gupta said the Delhi administration is committed to promoting cultural and spiritual traditions and will continue to support initiatives that foster community bonding and preserve heritage.



Delhi govt classifies digital printing on flex/vinyl/PVC as Green Category

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major boost to Delhi’s Ease of Doing Business (EoDB) push, the city government has reclassified digital printing on flex, vinyl and PVC under the Green Category, paving the way for faster approvals and reduced regulatory delays for the sector. The move aligns the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) with the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) norms and is expected to benefit a large number of small and medium enterprises.

Announcing the reform, Industries and Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa described it as a significant step towards balancing environmental protection with economic growth. “This is another big move towards EoDB after we relaxed the CTO timeline for Green Category industries last year. For entrepreneurs in Delhi’s vibrant printing sector, aligning with CPCB’s scientific categorization fosters responsible growth without compromising our war on pollution,” he said. He also thanked Chief Minister Rekha Gupta for her support in implementing the reform.

Shakarpur gets Arogya Mandir boost as MCD lays foundation

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi on Thursday laid the foundation stone of an ‘Arogya Mandir’ at Sanjay Park in Shakarpur, aiming to strengthen access to primary healthcare services at the local level. The ceremony was led by Delhi Mayor Sardar Raja Iqbal Singh.

The initiative is expected to provide improved and accessible healthcare facilities to residents, reducing the need to travel long distances for basic medical treatment. Speaking at the event, the Mayor said the project reflects a continued focus on citizen welfare and strengthening urban health infrastructure.

Among those present were Member of Parliament Harsh Malhotra, MLA Abhay Verma, Shahdara South Zone Chairman Ram Kishore Sharma, along with senior municipal officials and local residents.

Addressing the gathering, Singh highlighted that initiatives such as the Arogya Mandir are part of broader efforts to ensure equitable healthcare access. He noted that strengthening primary healthcare systems is essential for addressing routine medical needs efficiently while easing the burden on larger hospitals.

The Mayor also directed officials to ensure that construction is completed within a stipulated timeframe, maintaining transparency and quality standards.



He reiterated the Corporation’s commitment to prioritising public welfare projects and improving civic amenities across the city.

Public representatives at the event described the project as a significant step in local development, stating that it would enhance the quality of life for residents. They also underscored the importance of continued investment in healthcare infrastructure at the grassroots level.

The Arogya Mandir initiative is part of ongoing efforts by the civic body to build a more responsive and inclusive urban healthcare system, with a focus on accessibility, efficiency, and community well-being.

Students in civic chat with Mayor

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Students from Deshbandhu College met Sardar Raja Iqbal Singh at the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, gaining insights into urban administration, waste management, and grievance systems. The Mayor urged youth participation, highlighting transparency and accountability in strengthening citizen-centric governance and addressing civic challenges effectively.

DJB acts on bills, sewers, Yamuna River

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a push to resolve long-standing water-related grievances, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) has approved a series of projects targeting billing errors, sewer connectivity gaps and pollution in the Yamuna, marking a shift towards citizen-focused service delivery.

Chaired by Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, the Board cleared initiatives aimed at addressing daily challenges faced by residents, including faulty water bills, non-functional meters and

lack of sewer infrastructure in several colonies.

A key highlight is a city-wide e-KYC and digital database update drive covering nearly 35 lakh consumers. The project, estimated at Rs 60 crore, will introduce technology-enabled meter readings with photo capture, GPS tagging for accuracy and proof-based bill delivery to reduce discrepancies.

Explaining the rationale, Singh said, “People of Delhi want to pay their water bills and fulfill their responsibility. The problem arises when someone suddenly receives an inflated bill, when a meter is

not functioning, or when bills don’t reach households on time. These are not small issues, they affect daily life.” He added, “Our effort is to fix these gaps at the ground level and build a system that is accurate, transparent, and trustworthy.” The minister noted that the initiative aims to restore public trust, with verified digital records for all consumers expected within six months, reducing disputes and improving efficiency.

In a major infrastructure push, the Board also approved large-scale House Service Sewer Connections (HSSCs) in Kirari and nearby areas, benefiting

lakhs of residents across multiple colonies and villages. The move is expected to significantly improve sanitation and living conditions.

Additionally, the DJB has sanctioned projects to curb pollution in the Yamuna River, including in-situ wastewater treatment at the Delhi Gate drain and revival of the pondage area near the Wazirabad barrage.

Officials said these steps aim to intercept untreated sewage at the source, reflecting a broader strategy to improve water quality while addressing everyday civic concerns.

Speaker launches AI chatbot ‘Vidhan Sathi’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Thursday launched ‘Vidhan Sathi’, an AI-enabled chatbot, ahead of the upcoming Budget Session.

Gupta said the artificial intelligence (AI) tool will function as a legislative research assistant for members of the House. “The Vidhan Sathi app can be accessed by all MLAs of the assembly. This will be the country’s first legislative assembly to have such an AI-enabled tool,” he added.

The chatbot is integrated with existing AI tools and will

assist legislators in fact-checking, accessing parliamentary rules, and making debates more tech-friendly, the Speaker said.

Describing the app as a step towards a “tech-friendly” legislative assembly, he said that the app will be available in both Hindi and English and can be accessed via QR code. The support tool will be incorporated with the National e-Vidhan Sabha (NeVA) platform soon, he added. The Budget Session is scheduled from March 23 to March 25, during which pending CAG reports will also be tabled, the Speaker said.

Min expands fire audit to homes across Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major push to strengthen urban safety, Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood has ordered a comprehensive fire safety audit across the national capital, extending its scope beyond commercial establishments to include residential areas as well.

The move aims to eliminate what the government describes as “blind spots” in the city’s safety framework. Officials said the audit will cover all types of establishments operating within residential zones, ensuring stricter compliance with fire safety norms.

According to the directive, third-party experts will be engaged to conduct the audit, with a focus on speed, transparency and accountability. The initiative is expected to systematically assess fire preparedness across the city and identify potential risks before they escalate into emergencies.



KEY POINTS

- » The move aims to eliminate what the government describes as ‘blind spots’ in the city’s safety framework
- » Officials said the audit will cover all types of establishments operating within residential zones, ensuring stricter compliance with fire safety norms
- » According to the directive, third-party experts will be engaged to conduct the audit, with a focus on speed, transparency and accountability
- » The initiative is expected to systematically assess fire preparedness across the city and identify potential risks before they escalate into emergencies

amid growing concerns over fire incidents in densely populated areas, particularly where commercial activities operate within residential neighbourhoods.

Officials noted that detailed guidelines and timelines for the audit will be issued soon. The initiative is expected to significantly enhance safety compliance and ensure that fire prevention measures are uniformly implemented across Delhi.

About 65 services of govt to be available on WhatsApp

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi citizens may soon be able to avail around 65 Delhi government services such as caste and income certificates, and driving licence through a WhatsApp governance initiative likely to be launched next month, officials said on Thursday.

The services to be availed through the app will be increased in a phased manner after its launch which is likely after the Budget session, said a senior government functionary.

The Budget session of the Delhi Assembly will be held from March 23 to March 25.

The initiative aims to offer seamless access to government services via WhatsApp, allowing users to submit applications, receive notifications and obtain certificates through AI-enabled chatbots and WhatsApp Dynamic Flows, officials said.

The project involves bringing various services of the government available online, including the issuance of

important documents like birth and caste certificate, in a faceless manner through WhatsApp, they said.

It will ensure a simple, user-friendly and 24x7 digital governance interface, the officials said.

The digital governance model will help people in availing a range of services without the need to make visits to the offices of departments concerned, by offering real-time updates and efficient service delivery in a given time period, they said.

Nearly 65 services which are available online through the e-district portal of the government covering revenue, transport, social welfare and other departments, would also be available through WhatsApp, they said.

The Information Technology (IT) Department of the Delhi government working on the project will also come up with a dashboard for real-time monitoring and management of the applications and their time-bound disposal, they added.

WETTEST MARCH SINCE 2023 Rains, gusty winds sweep Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Rain and gusty winds swept the national capital on Thursday, sending the day temperature dipping sharply, and turning March into the wettest in three years, with an average of 9.4 mm of precipitation. The maximum temperature settled at 26.8 degrees Celsius, the lowest so far this month.

The IMD has issued an orange alert for the city till 11.15 pm.

According to the weather office, an orange alert stands for “be prepared” for severe weather conditions that could disrupt daily life, including transport and routine activities.

Meanwhile, a persistent cloud cover and intermittent rainfall brought relief to the city, sweltering in warmer conditions for days. The rainfall recorded during the day stood at 8.2 mm at the city’s base observatory.

At Safdarjung, the city’s base station, 9.4 mm of average rainfall has been recorded till March 19 against a normal monthly average of 12.6 mm.

The last time higher rainfall

was recorded in March was in 2023, when the monthly total stood at 50.4 mm, underlining the intensity of the current spell.

Rainfall was recorded at Safdarjung (8.2 mm), Palam (6.2 mm), Lodhi Road (8.2 mm), Ridge (8.6 mm) and Ayanagar (7.2 mm) till 8.30 am, while other stations such as Pitampura (5.5 mm), Pusa (11.0 mm), Mayur Vihar (3.0 mm) and Janakpuri (12.5 mm) also recorded showers, reflecting precipitation across the capital with varying intensity.

Light rainfall was recorded across parts of Delhi also on Wednesday. At Safdarjung, a trace of rainfall was recorded between 8.30 am and 11.30 am.

Ayanagar recorded relatively higher rainfall of 0.5 mm till 2.30 pm and 0.7 mm by 5.30 pm. Mayur Vihar recorded 3.0 mm of precipitation. On Thursday, maximum temperatures across the city remained below normal, with Safdarjung and Lodhi Road recording 26.8 degrees Celsius, 4.5 and 3.2 degrees below normal.

Ridge recorded 26.5 degrees Celsius, 5.3 degrees below nor-

mal, while Palam and Ayanagar recorded 25.3 degrees Celsius and 25.2 degrees Celsius, 6.3 degrees and 6.8 degrees below normal.

The city recorded a minimum temperature of 17.6 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung, which is 1.1 degrees above normal. Palam and Ridge recorded 17.0 degrees Celsius, 0.6 degrees above normal and 0.7 degrees below normal.

Lodhi Road recorded 17.7 degrees Celsius, 2.7 degrees above normal, while Ayanagar recorded 18.2 degrees Celsius, 2.0 degrees above normal, indicating relatively warmer nights at some stations despite the rainy conditions.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) had earlier predicted “hailstorm and thunderstorm with moderate rainfall and lightning (40–50 kmph gusty winds)” in Delhi, Noida, Dadri, and Greater Noida.

The IMD has forecast similar conditions for Friday, with light to moderate rainfall, thunderstorms and gusty winds likely to continue over parts of Delhi-NCR.

SUPPLY CURBS ON COMMERCIAL CONSUMERS REMAIN IN PLACE

LPG bookings close to normal, but situation still ‘worrisome’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Bookings for domestic LPG refills are approaching pre-war normal levels, signalling a gradual return to normalcy, but concerns persist as supply restrictions on commercial consumers, including hotels, remain in place due to ongoing disruptions in input supplies caused by the West Asia conflict.

Over 33 crore domestic LPG consumers had, on average, booked about 55 lakh cylinders daily before the February 28 military strikes by the US and Israel on Iran. The escalation triggered sweeping retaliation from Tehran, effectively shutting the Strait of Hormuz - a critical shipping corridor used by major Gulf producers such as Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the UAE to export crude oil, gas and LPG to key markets including India.



People wait in a queue with empty LPG cooking gas cylinders in Noida on Thursday *PII*

The shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz blocked India's access to almost 60 per cent of its LPG, leading to curtailment of supplies to commercial users and triggering panic buying by domestic users, which peaked to 87.7 lakh on March 13.

Bookings have since fallen to 56-57 lakh on March 18, said Sujata Sharma, Joint Sec-

retary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

"Panic booking is coming down," she said, adding that the government continues to prioritise the supply of available LPG to domestic households.

However, "LPG (supply) situation remains worrisome but there is no dry out at any LPG distributor," she said.

Commercial users are

Highlights

» Over 33 crore domestic LPG consumers had, on average, booked about 55 lakh cylinders daily before Feb 28

» Bookings have since fallen to 56-57 lakh on March 18, said the Joint Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas

getting just a fifth of their requirement.

Sharma said domestic LPG production has increased by over 40 per cent in the last two weeks and the three public sector oil marketing companies have been making normal, pre-war levels of daily deliveries of LPG refills.

"Our supply has not dipped. Some days the supply has been

higher (than pre-war times). On March 18, 54.91 lakh LPG cylinders were delivered against a booking of over 56 lakh," she said.

Oil companies are operating extra shifts to keep LPG deliveries in pace with the bookings. They delivered 62.5 lakh cylinders on March 13 and 60 lakh on March 14 - the peak two days of panic bookings.

LPG supplies are under close monitoring amid the prevailing geopolitical tensions, with no dry-outs reported at distributorships and domestic cylinder deliveries continuing uninterrupted, she said. Online bookings have risen sharply to 94 per cent, while Delivery Authentication Code (a unique OTP that is sent to registered mobile numbers of actual users to ensure LPG is being delivered to correct customers) coverage has expanded to 83 per cent.

MEA: 280 PILGRIMS RETURNED

‘Indians returning from Iran via Armenia and Azerbaijan’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Nearly 880 Indian nationals, including students who had been stranded in Iran due to the conflict in West Asia, have started to return to India through Armenia and Azerbaijan, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Thursday.

At the weekly media briefing, MEA Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal also said, of the 284 pilgrims who had gone to Iran, about 280 have returned via Armenia, and three-four of them are expected to arrive in a couple of days.

"Some people do not register with the Indian Embassy. So, our estimate was that about 9,000 people were there (in Iran). Many of the students had returned before the strikes began. And recently, nearly 882 Indian nationals, including students, people from the business community, and pilgrims, had gone from India," he said.

Jaiswal was asked for an

The MEA's Control Room set up on March 4 remains fully functional, supporting the needs of the Indian nationals

update on Indian nationals in Iran who wish to return to the country.

"These 882 Indian nationals, via Armenia and Azerbaijan, are expected to return, some have returned. A total of 772 are returning via Armenia, and through Azerbaijan, 110, out of whom, some have returned, while others are coming back," he said.

He also said that the MEA's Control Room set up on March 4 here remains fully functional, supporting the needs of the Indian nationals.

Jaiswal said the number of calls or emails has reduced sig-

nificantly. The issues of people getting stranded have been largely addressed, and calls and emails have gone down significantly, and helplines in the Indian embassies in various countries in the region are working 24x7, he added.

The MEA spokesperson further said, "We have a large number of students, including girl students from Kashmir who are getting medical education in Iran. We had issued an advisory, we had told everybody to get in touch with the Embassy before crossing the Azerbaijan border, so they could help them in crossing the Iran-Azerbaijan border."

As the conflict in West Asia widened with global ramifications, India on Thursday said the situation has been a "testing time", not just for the country, but the entire global community.

The West Asia conflict began on February 28 when the US-Israel combine launched military strikes on Iran. In retaliation, Tehran has targeted Gulf countries hosting US military bases.

Rajnath cites global conflicts, says India must become self-reliant in drone manufacturing

NEW DELHI: India must develop a robust ecosystem for drone manufacturing to enhance its defence preparedness, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Thursday, highlighting lessons from the Russia-Ukraine and Iran-Israel conflicts.

In an address at an event, Singh asserted that the two conflicts prove that drones and counter-drone technologies will play a 'pivotal role' in future warfare.

The defence minister said India must work in mission mode to emerge as a global hub for indig-

enous drone manufacturing in the next few years to ensure strategic autonomy and boost military prowess.

"As the entire world watches the ongoing conflict involving Russia and Ukraine, along with Iran-Israel, we can clearly see the extremely significant role of drones and counter-drone technologies in future warfare," he said.

"Today, there is a need to build such a drone manufacturing ecosystem in India, in which we are completely self-reliant," he said.

Singh was speaking at the

Singh asserted that the ongoing conflicts prove that drones and counter-drone technologies will play a 'pivotal role' in future warfare

National Defence Industries conclave, which was attended by top executives of leading domestic defence manufacturing firms as well as officials of defence public sector undertakings.

"For India's defence preparedness and strategic autonomy, it is essential that India becomes fully self-reliant in drone manufactur-

ing," he said.

"From the drone's moulds to its software, engines, batteries and everything must be manufactured in India. This is no easy task," he said.

"In most countries where drones are manufactured, a significant number of critical components are currently imported from China," he added.

The defence minister also touched upon growing significance of artificial intelligence, robotics and other new and critical technologies.

"In today's era, innovations such as automation, artificial intelligence, and robotics are transforming manufacturing across the world. Alongside these, simulation technology is also opening up new possibilities," he said.

Singh also called upon the industry leaders to focus on improving quality of their products.

"This self-reliance is necessary not only at the product level but also

at the component level. That is, from the drone's mould to the software, engine, and batteries -- all should be made in India," he said.

Singh argued that while the creation of any nation's defence industrial ecosystem relies on the contributions of industries, MSMEs and start-ups, it is equally driven by a clear policy push tailored to meet specific defence requirements.

The defence minister called for active contribution of the private sector and extended the Modi-led government's full support to trans-

form India into a global hub for indigenous drone manufacturing.

Singh also launched the 14th edition of Defence India Start-up Challenge (DISC-14) and the fourth edition of ADITI (Acing Development of Innovative Technologies with iDEX) challenges.

A total of 107 problem statements, including 82 under DISC-14 and 25 under ADITI Challenges 4.0, from the defence forces, Indian Coast Guard and Defence Space Agency were launched to promote breakthrough innovations in various domains.

MPOST

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Iran steps up

Authorities in Abu Dhabi said they were forced to shut down operations at its Habshan gas facility and Bab field, calling Iranian overnight attacks on the sites a "dangerous escalation".

In Israel, more than a half-dozen waves of Iranian attacks targeting large parts of the country sent millions of people to shelters. The strikes caused damage to buildings but no significant casualties were reported.

The Iranian attacks came after Israel hit South Pars, the Iranian part of the world's largest gas field located offshore in the Persian Gulf and owned jointly with Qatar.

Iran's attack on Qatar's energy infrastructure in retaliation for an Israeli strike on the Iranian South Pars gas facility is bad news for India, with over 88% import dependence on crude oil and about 50% on gas. The war had already disrupted India's gas imports from its single-biggest supplier, Qatar, which supplied about one-third of its total liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and about half of its liquefied natural gas (LNG) imports.

Even after the war ends or eases, problems for India will depend on the extent of damage done by the Iranian strike at Ras Laffan because LNG and PNG supplies from there would depend on the time taken to repair its facilities.

Indian firms such as Petronet LNG Ltd (PLL), GAIL India, and GSPC have long-term commercially beneficial gas supply contracts with Qatar.

With some 80 per cent of all power generated in Iran coming from natural gas, according to the Paris-based International Energy Agency, the attack directly threatens the country's electricity supplies. Natural gas is also used to supply household heating and cooking across the Islamic Republic.

Iran condemned the strike on South Pars, with President Masoud Pezeshkian warning of "uncontrollable consequences" that "could engulf the entire world".

In Washington, President Donald Trump said that Israel would not attack South Pars again, but warned on social media that if Iran continued striking Qatar's energy infrastructure, the US would retaliate and "massively blow up the entirety" of the field. "I do not want to authorize

this level of violence and destruction because of the long term implications that it will have on the future of Iran," Trump said on social media.

Meanwhile, Iran announced the execution of three men detained in January's nationwide protests, the first such sentences known to have been carried out, the judiciary's Mizan news agency reported.

More than 1,300 people in Iran have been killed during the war. Israeli strikes against the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon have displaced more than 1 million people -- roughly 20 per cent of the population -- according to the Lebanese government, which says more than 900 people have been killed.

In Israel, 15 people have been killed by Iranian missile fire. Four people were also killed in the occupied West Bank overnight by an Iranian missile strike, according to officials. At least 13 US military members have been killed.

India condemns

civilian infrastructure, including energy infrastructure, across the region," External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at his weekly media briefing.

"The recent attacks against energy installations in different locations across this region are therefore deeply disturbing and only serve to further destabilise an already uncertain energy scenario for the whole world," he said.

"Such attacks are unacceptable and need to cease," Jaiswal said without naming any country.

As concerns mounted over the escalating situation in West Asia, PM Modi spoke to Oman's Sultan Haitham bin Tariq, Jordan King, French President Emmanuel Macron and Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim.

In his conversation with the Omani Sultan, Modi also spoke about the need for free passage through the Strait of Hormuz, a strategically key shipping lane.

"We agreed on the need to prioritize dialogue and diplomacy for de-escalation and subsequent restoration of peace and stability," the prime minister said on social media.

Modi said he also reiterated India's condemnation of the violation of Oman's sovereignty and territorial integrity and appreciated the Gulf nation's efforts to facilitate the safe return of thousands of people, including Indian nationals.

"India and Oman stand for safe and free navigation through the Strait of Hormuz," Modi said.

Oman is among the Gulf nations bearing the brunt of Iranian retaliation following strikes by Israel and the US on Iranian targets.

Following his phone conversation with Macron on the situation in West Asia, Modi said there is an "urgent need for de-escalation, as well as a return to dialogue and diplomacy".

"We look forward to continuing our close coordination to advance peace and stability in the region and beyond," he said.

Macron said India and France are "working closely together to reduce tensions in the region and to keep diplomacy at the heart of our efforts for peace".

After speaking to Ibrahim, Modi said: "We also discussed the deeply concerning situation in West Asia and reaffirmed our shared commitment to de-escalation and the early restoration of peace and stability through dialogue and diplomacy."

On his talks with Jordan King, Modi said India and Jordan stand in support of "unhindered transit of goods and energy".

"We expressed concern at the evolving situation in West Asia and highlighted the need for dialogue and diplomacy for the early restoration of peace, security and stability in the region," Modi said.

"Attacks on energy infrastructure in West Asia are condemnable and can lead to avoidable escalation," he said.

"Deeply appreciated Jordan's efforts in facilitating the safe return of Indians stranded in the region," he added.

As the overall situation deteriorated further in West Asia, several global leaders called for de-escalation of the situation.

"It is time to open a path towards de-escalation in order to restore stability in the Middle East," French President Macron said.

"France calls for the immediate implementation of a moratorium on strikes targeting civilian infrastructure, whether related to water or to energy. Freedom and security of navigation must be restored," he said.

Macron said tempers must cool and hostilities must cease, in order to give a real chance to the prospect of a negotiated solution to the crisis.

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz indicated that US President Donald Trump is willing to halt the military action.

Stock market

Since the onset of the West Asia crisis on February 28, investors have seen wealth erosion

exceeding Rs 37 lakh crore.

Market participants attributed the downturn to heightened geopolitical risks. "Indian equity markets witnessed a sharp reversal today, breaking their three-day recovery rally," said Ponnudi R, CEO of Enrich Money. He noted that renewed strikes involving Israel and Iran targeting key oil and LNG facilities have intensified fears of supply disruptions.

Brent crude prices jumped 6.21 per cent to USD 114 per barrel, adding to market anxiety. Ajit Mishra of Religare Broking said the spike in oil prices, alongside a hawkish US Federal Reserve stance and persistent foreign institutional investor outflows, further pressured sentiment.

Heavyweight stocks including Eternal, Bajaj Finance, Mahindra & Mahindra, HDFC Bank, Larsen & Toubro and InterGlobe Aviation led the decline. HDFC Bank dropped 5.13 per cent after chairman Atanu Chakraborty resigned citing ethical concerns.

Broader indices also fell, with the BSE MidCap Select down 3.34 per cent and SmallCap Select losing 2.77 per cent. All sectoral indices ended in the red, led by auto, realty and financial services.

On the BSE, 3,192 stocks declined, while 1,051 advanced and 161 remained unchanged.

RBI assures

years before his extended term was due to end in May 2027.

In his resignation letter dated March 17 and addressed to Nomination and Remuneration Committee chairman Harsh Kumar Bhanwala, Chakraborty wrote that "certain happenings and practices within the bank" over the past two years were not aligned with his personal values and ethics. He clarified that there were no other material reasons behind his decision.

The bank's board and management, however, said they were unable to identify any specific issues raised by Chakraborty. Chief executive and managing director Sashidhar Jagdishan told reporters that every board member had urged him to reconsider his decision, explain the concerns in detail, or even soften the language used in the resignation letter. "He did not relent," Jagdishan said, adding that the lack of specifics left the board "baffled".

Independent directors echoed this sentiment. M D Ranganath said the board had repeatedly asked for concrete instances to substantiate the claims, but none were provided.

Renu Sud Karnad also noted that Chakraborty did not elaborate on the allegations mentioned in his letter.

Following the resignation, four board members, including two whole-time and two independent directors, engaged with the RBI on Wednesday evening. The regulator subsequently approved the bank's proposal to appoint Keki Mistry as interim part-time chairman for three months starting March 19, 2026. The RBI also indicated it would continue to engage with the bank's board and management on the way forward.

Mistry, a veteran banker and former executive vice chairman of HDFC Ltd, said he would not have accepted the interim role if he had doubts about the bank's governance standards. He maintained that the institution upholds transparency, trust and integrity, and suggested that routine operational issues should not be misconstrued as systemic problems. He also hinted at a possible "personal relationship issue" behind the resignation but declined to elaborate.

The development triggered a steep decline in HDFC Bank's stock. Shares fell 5.13 per cent to close at Rs 799.70 on the BSE, after plunging as much as 8.41 per cent during intra-day trade to hit a 52-week low of Rs 772. On the NSE, the stock dropped 5.31 per cent to Rs 798.20, with a low of Rs 770 during the session.

The sell-off wiped out Rs 65,946.08 crore from the bank's market valuation, bringing it down to Rs 12,30,896.85 crore.

Addressing speculation about possible regulatory or operational triggers, Jagdishan dismissed suggestions that an earlier issue involving the bank's Dubai operations had any connection to Chakraborty's resignation. Ranganath added that the matter had already been investigated, accountability fixed and disciplinary action completed, and was now closed.

Senior management also underlined that the bank's merger with HDFC Ltd, completed in July 2023 and creating a combined balance sheet exceeding Rs 18 lakh crore, has yielded tangible benefits. Deputy managing director Kaizad Bharcha said the integration has led to a rise in savings account relationships among home loan customers, with average balances in such accounts being 2.5 times the bank's overall average.

Chakraborty, a 1985-batch IAS officer of the Gujarat cadre, joined HDFC Bank as part-time chairman in May 2021 after serving as Secretary of the Department of Economic

Affairs. He had also previously led the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management.

With the interim leadership now in place, the bank's Nomination and Remuneration Committee is expected to meet within a month to deliberate on both the appointment of a new chairman and the reappointment of Jagdishan, whose term is set to end in about seven months.

Govt classifies

a key route for India's imports. Before the conflict, more than half of India's crude oil imports came from countries such as Saudi Arabia, Iraq and the UAE via the strait. Around 85 to 95 per cent of LPG and nearly 30 per cent of natural gas supplies also passed through the same route.

India depends heavily on imports, sourcing about 88 per cent of its crude oil, 50 per cent of natural gas and 60 per cent of LPG from overseas. While crude supplies have been partly rerouted from regions such as Russia, West Africa, the United States and Latin America, shortages of gas and LPG from Gulf nations have affected industrial and commercial users.

Officials said the new framework is intended to create a centralised, near real-time data system that allows quicker responses to supply disruptions. It is also expected to support prioritisation of critical sectors, including power generation, fertiliser production and household LPG distribution.

The order has been issued under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955, which empowers the Centre to seek information related to production, supply, distribution and stockholding of essential goods. According to the government, establishing a systematic mechanism for collecting and analysing such data is necessary in the public interest to ensure effective monitoring of the petroleum and natural gas supply chain.

The mandate covers a wide spectrum of stakeholders, including crude oil producers, oil marketing companies, storage operators, LNG terminal operators, gas pipeline companies and city gas distribution networks. Industry participants will need to upgrade their data systems to meet the stricter reporting requirements as the regulatory framework evolves.

Officials indicated that ensuring energy security will increasingly rely on real-time visibility across supply chains alongside diversified sourcing strategies.

RBI explores new avenues

He also called for more INR-Rouble transactions, noting that consistent activity would help the market develop further over time.

HC affirms

to followers of Islam. Instead, it underlined that the provision is neutral and applies equally to all religions, as well as to individuals who do not subscribe to any faith. The judges noted that the freedom of conscience protected under Article 25 extends even to atheists, allowing them to express their beliefs through reason and logic. Highlighting India's diversity, the court observed that the country's strength lies in the coexistence of multiple religions, cultures and languages among its 1.4 billion people. It pointed out that different faiths follow distinct traditions of congregation, citing examples such as Friday prayers in Islam, Sunday mass in Christianity and Sabbath observance in Judaism, while noting that some Eastern religions do not have fixed days for communal worship.

The plea was ultimately disposed of with directions to the state to ensure compliance with constitutional protections and previous judicial rulings concerning religious gatherings on private property.

India appoints

MEA in 2000 and a subsequent stint in the Prime Minister's Office, where he served as private secretary to the prime minister.

He has also served at India's Permanent Mission to the United Nations in New York and at the Consulate General in Johannesburg. In 2011, he headed the SAARC division, followed by a tenure as joint secretary in the Americas Division from 2012 to 2014.

Doraiswami later served as ambassador to Uzbekistan and envoy to the Republic of Korea. He returned to MEA headquarters in 2018, overseeing the Bangladesh and Myanmar division, and later handled International Organisations and Summits.

Before his UK posting in September 2022, he was High Commissioner to Bangladesh from October 2020 to September 2022. Doraiswami speaks Mandarin, French and some Korean.

EDITORIAL
DOMINANCE
MYTH

When Donald Trump returned to the White House, he moved swiftly to recast America's energy policy around a familiar idea: fossil fuels as the backbone of national strength. Renewable energy programmes were curtailed, regulations rolled back, and oil and gas production prioritised in the name of "energy dominance." The premise was politically potent and intuitively appealing—produce more at home, rely less on others, and shield the economy from global disruptions. Yet the unfolding war involving Iran is exposing the limits of that doctrine. As tensions escalate in West Asia and the Strait of Hormuz remains effectively constrained, the United States finds itself once again entangled in the very volatility it sought to escape. Instead of insulation, American consumers are facing a surge in energy prices that highlights the deep connection between fossil fuels and geopolitics.

The spike in crude oil prices beyond USD 100 a barrel and the steady climb in gasoline costs toward USD 4 a gallon are not anomalies; they are the predictable outcome of a system dependent on fragile global supply chains. Nearly a fifth of the world's traded oil typically passes through the Strait of Hormuz, making it one of the most critical chokepoints in the global energy network. When that artery is threatened, the shockwaves travel instantly across markets. No level of domestic drilling can fully offset disruptions in such a tightly interconnected system. Fossil fuels, by their very nature, are subject to the uncertainties of conflict, sanctions and strategic rivalry. The current crisis is a reminder that energy dominance built on hydrocarbons is never absolute; it is contingent, vulnerable and perpetually exposed to forces beyond national control.

What has made the impact more acute is the narrowing of alternatives. By scaling back investments in renewable energy and halting or delaying clean energy projects, the administration has reduced the diversity of America's energy mix at a time when resilience should have been the priority. Renewable sources such as wind and solar operate outside the logic of geopolitical chokepoints. They do not depend on shipping lanes, nor can they be embargoed or disrupted by military conflict. Their value lies not only in reducing emissions but also in stabilising long-term energy costs. The decision to sideline them has effectively concentrated risk rather than dispersing it. In doing so, it has left households and industries more exposed to precisely the kind of price shocks now unfolding, where external events translate quickly into domestic economic strain.

To its credit, the administration has attempted to manage the immediate fallout. The release of oil from the Strategic Petroleum Reserve, the easing of certain restrictions on global supply, and discussions around securing tanker routes through military means all signal a recognition of the crisis. Yet these measures are fundamentally reactive. They address symptoms rather than causes, offering temporary relief without resolving the structural dependence that created the vulnerability in the first place. President Trump's assertion that the economic pain is a "small price to pay" reflects a broader strategic calculation, but it risks underestimating the cumulative impact of sustained high energy costs on households, businesses and political sentiment. Energy prices are not abstract indicators; they shape everyday realities, from transport costs to inflation, and their rise can quickly erode public confidence.

The deeper lesson of the current moment is not that fossil fuels are obsolete, but that reliance on them alone is insufficient in a world defined by uncertainty. Energy security in the 21st century requires diversification, flexibility and foresight. A balanced system—one that combines conventional fuels with renewable sources—offers a buffer against disruption and a pathway to stability. As global institutions and climate experts have long argued, the transition to cleaner energy is as much about resilience as it is about sustainability. The war in Iran has brought that argument into sharp relief. It has been demonstrated that strategic strength cannot be measured solely in barrels of oil produced, but in the capacity to withstand shocks without cascading economic consequences. In that sense, the true test of energy policy is not how it performs in times of stability, but how it endures in moments of crisis—and by that measure, the current approach stands exposed.

ENERGY
HORIZON



SANJAY AGARWAL

THE WRITER IS
FORMER SECURITY
ADVISOR, MINISTRY
OF HOME
AFFAIRS, GOI

The SHANTI Act, 2025, replaces the older Atomic Energy Act framework and creates a more contemporary architecture for India's nuclear sector

Thorium as India's Energy Hedge

Thorium is back in India's energy debate, but success now depends on building institutions, financing and capacity to move from research to reality

Thorium is re-emerging as a strategic lever in India's quest for reliable, low-carbon energy security, but policy, technology and institutional gaps must be closed quickly, if it is to move from promise to power plant. **Global Promise, Indian Legacy** Globally, thorium has long been seen as a safer, more abundant alternative to uranium. Experiments in the US and Europe in the 1950s-70s never translated into commercial-scale outputs because cheap uranium, light-water reactor dominance and weapons-linked fuel cycles drove investment elsewhere.

India was the notable outlier: Dr Homi Bhabha's three-stage nuclear programme was explicitly designed around its vast thorium reserves, using natural uranium and heavy water reactors in Stage-1, fast breeder reactors in Stage-2, and thorium-fuelled systems in Stage-3.

Yet, even in India, large-scale thorium deployment remains delayed. Parliamentary replies (2015) projected commercial thorium reactors 3-4 decades after sustained Fast Breeder Test Reactor (FBTR) achieve scale in the 2040s - implying 2070-2080 timelines. Today, Bhabha Atomic Research Centre's (BARC) Advanced Heavy Water Reactor (AHWR) - deriving ~60 per cent of power from thorium - symbolises both technological readiness and the persistent "pilot-plant purgatory" trapping thorium development.

Why India's Thorium Plans Slipped India's long-term nuclear planning erred less in vision and more in sequencing, resourcing and political economy. The three-stage strategy assumed: rapid scaling of heavy-water reactors, timely fast breeder deployment and an industrial ecosystem capable of complex fuel fabrication - assumptions repeatedly undercut by sanctions, financing constraints and project delays. Public sector dominance under the Atomic Energy Act 1962 created a closed, cautious culture; innovation and scale were locked within a few PSUs and research centres, with little competitive pressure or global integration.

These lapses forced reliance on coal/imports longer than planned. While Pressurised Heavy Water Reactor (PHWR) (Stage-1) capacity grew, Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) and thorium stages



Thorium remains strategically relevant because it offers India a long-horizon domestic fuel option within a low-carbon framework

(Stage 2 & 3) lagged. **SHANTI Act: A Structural Reset of our Nuclear Framework**

The Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) Act (Dec 2025) replaces the Atomic Energy Act 1962 + Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act 2010. It permits private Indian companies to build, own and operate reactors, and to participate in fuel fabrication, including conversion, refining and enrichment of Uranium-235 up to a government-defined threshold, while reserving "sensitive" activities for the state. The Act moves from a single statutory operator-liability cap towards a graded liability framework, aligning more closely with international practice and improving project bankability.

Crucially, SHANTI allows patents for peaceful applications of atomic energy, subject to national-security exclusions. This can attract capital and talent into reactor design, advanced materials and fuel-cycle services. For thorium, this opens space for joint ventures and privately led demonstration projects in parallel with the three-stage PSU-dominated track, potentially compressing timelines and diversifying risk.

India's Wider Energy Security Playbook India's thorium debate sits within a far broader diversification drive across renew-

ables and non-fossil sources. As of Dec 2024, the country had installed about 209 GW of renewable capacity, up from 180.8 GW a year earlier, with a record 28.6 GW added in 2024 alone. Solar led this surge, jumping from 73.3 GW to 97.9 GW in a single year, while wind climbed to about 48.2 GW.

Analysis suggests India could meet 2030 power demand without adding new coal capacity, if it achieves the 500 GW non-fossil target (per updated Nationally Determined Contribution - NDC), backed by storage and grid upgrades. In 2025, the Union Cabinet announced that India had already crossed the 50 per cent non-fossil share in total power capacity, achieving this Paris-pledge milestone five years ahead of the 2030 deadline. This mix—solar, wind, hydro, nuclear and legacy thermal—underpins a geopolitical strategy of reducing import dependence on coal and gas exporters, leveraging climate finance, and positioning India as a manufacturing and green-hydrogen hub.

COB SDGs and the G7 Benchmarks Under the 2030 NDC (at the COP 21, Paris, 2015), India committed to two things. Cutting emissions intensity per unit of GDP by 45 per cent from 2005 levels, and achieving 50 per cent of installed electricity capacity from non-fossil sources by 2030. Both

trajectories are ahead of the original Paris pledges: India had already reduced emissions intensity by about 33 per cent by 2019, and surpassed the earlier 40 per cent non-fossil capacity target well before 2030.

By mid-2025, the government reported breaching the more ambitious 50 per cent non-fossil capacity mark five years ahead of schedule, effectively placing India about nine years ahead of its initial Paris commitments. Among G7 economies, most are moving strongly on coal phase-out and renewables, but still over-rely on gas and have an "ambition gap" in renewable capacity relative to a tripling target from 0.9 TW in 2022 to 2.7 TW in 2030; Japan is widely seen as the laggard, while the EU-based members and the UK are comparatively stronger performers. India's early over-delivery on non-fossil capacity thus contrasts with G7 systems that, despite higher per-capita emissions and incomes, have not yet aligned gas use with net-zero-power timelines.

What India Still Needs to Do First, India must decisively move thorium from laboratory to limited-scale commercialisation by time-bound commissioning of AHWR-class reactors and integrating them into the 500 GW non-fossil roadmap. This will require: realistic cost models, international cooperation on safety and materials, and using SHANTI's private-sector opening to attract private capital.

Second, coal's share in power generation, though falling in capacity terms, remains high in actual generation. India needs aggressive grid expansion, storage, demand-response and flexible gas-plus-storage solutions to backstop high solar and wind shares, without locking into long-lived fossil assets.

Third, governance reforms—transparent project pipelines, faster land and transmission approvals, and clearer state-centre burden-sharing—will matter as much as technology in sustaining the current pace of renewables growth.

Policy message: India must treat thorium as a strategic hedge complementing, not replacing, the ongoing solar-wind-hydro build-out, with SHANTI as the bridge between a closed nuclear past and a more competitive, secure energy future.

Views expressed are personal

WAR
PARADOX



RAJDEEP PATHAK

THE WRITER IS
PROGRAMME
EXECUTIVE, GANDHI
SMRITI AND
DARSHAN SAMITI

What begins as a military operation rarely ends there. West Asia's crisis is now humanitarian, environmental and global

Cost of Strategic Dominance

Modern warfare may achieve swift tactical gains, but it often leaves behind fractured societies, poisoned environments and a future far harder to rebuild

The graveyards being dug today in the Middle East stand as a grim testament to a world that has chosen strategic dominance over human security. In modern warfare, the paradox is increasingly evident—the more successful a military campaign becomes at destroying its targets, the more it erodes the fragile foundations upon which future peace must stand. As of March 16, 2026, the escalating confrontation between Iran, the United States, and Israel has plunged West Asia into one of the most volatile crises of the century. What began as a calculated military operation has now evolved into a multidimensional catastrophe—geopolitical, humanitarian, and environmental.

For decades, the geopolitical equilibrium of West Asia survived through a fragile condition often described as "no war, no peace." That uneasy balance collapsed on February 28, 2026, when the United States and Israel launched a coordinated military campaign code-named Operation Epic Fury. The operation represented a new doctrine in modern warfare, resulting in the targeting and elimination of an adversary's entire leadership structure in a single coordinated strike.

The surprise airstrikes reportedly killed Iran's Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, along with several top military and political officials, including the Chief of Army Staff and the Defence Minister. Strategically, the strikes were intended to paralyse Iran's command system and force rapid political collapse. Yet, two weeks into the conflict, it has become clear that the decapitation of leadership has not ended the crisis. Instead, it has triggered a fierce and determined retaliation by an Iranian state fighting for survival.

From a purely tactical perspective, the operation may appear to be a military success. However, from a strategic standpoint, it risks becoming a profound miscalculation. Destroying a leadership hierarchy can dismantle a chain of command, but it can also create something far more unpredictable—that of a wounded state apparatus driven by ideological consolidation and existential desperation.

This transformation has pushed the conflict dangerously close to the nuclear threshold. With the death of key Iranian authorities, inspectors from the International Atomic Energy Agency have reportedly lost access to several critical nuclear facilities—suspected to be inside the rubble—creating the possibility of a nuclear breakout. The world is discovering that a regime with nothing to lose is far more dangerous than one with a system to protect.



Environmental fallout, including toxic 'black rain' in Tehran, now threatens to spread beyond borders, raising fears of a wider ecological disaster

Meanwhile, the conflict has begun to spread across the wider region. Iran has announced that it will reopen the Strait of Hormuz to international shipping—except to what its Foreign Minister, Abbas Araghchi, has described as "the enemies who carried out this cowardly aggression." Simultaneously, fresh missile and drone attacks have been reported in Bahrain, Qatar, and Jerusalem, signalling the escalation of a wider regional war.

Amid this escalating instability, the ongoing G20 emergency summit, convened to address the so-called "Black Rain" crisis, has descended into diplomatic deadlock. The summit reflects deep divisions within the international community. A Western-led bloc has demanded accountability for what it describes as environmental warfare, calling for immediate scientific access to the affected areas through the creation of a monitored "Green Corridor." China and Russia, however, have rejected attempts to attribute unilateral blame, arguing instead for immediate de-escalation and negotiations.

India, navigating a delicate diplomatic balance, has attempted to redirect the debate toward stabilising global energy markets and preventing economic disruption that could ripple across developing economies. Beyond the negotiating tables, the devastation looms large. By mid-March 2026, the humanitarian landscape will have deteriorated into a full-scale regional catastrophe. More than 2,120 deaths have been verified by the World Health Organisation (WHO) across Iran and Lebanon, including over 1,100 children. Thousands more remain missing beneath the rubble of bombed residential neighbourhoods. In Lebanon alone, nearly 14 per cent of the population

has been displaced into overcrowded shelters where basic infrastructure is rapidly collapsing.

In Tehran, the crisis has taken an even darker turn. Residents of the ten-million-strong metropolis are facing a phenomenon now widely referred to as "black rain"—a toxic mixture of oil soot and precipitation produced by burning industrial installations and atmospheric disturbances. Reports from hospitals describe widespread chemical burns, severe respiratory distress, and unexplained neurological symptoms. International aid organisations, already addressing ongoing conflicts, now find themselves struggling to respond to this rapidly progressing environmental crisis. Worsening cardiovascular diseases and increased vulnerability among children and the elderly are major concerns, as chronic inhalation of sulfur compounds can lead to irreversible lung damage and neurological complications.

Global health agencies have issued urgent warnings. According to assessments by the WHO and UNICEF, sulfur-laden toxic clouds rising from damaged industrial complexes are rapidly drifting across Central Asia and toward Afghanistan. What initially appeared to be a localised environmental incident now threatens to evolve into a transboundary ecological disaster.

Environmental scientists also warn that such airborne pollutants can have devastating long-term consequences. Sulfur dioxide and related gases can acidify soil, poison agricultural land, and contaminate rivers that sustain rural communities. In regions where livelihoods depend heavily on farming, the destruction of fertile soil can trigger cascading crises—from crop failures to food

shortages and forced migration.

The situation is particularly precarious in Afghanistan. After decades of conflict, the country's environmental monitoring systems and healthcare networks remain fragile. Communities already grappling with poverty and climate-induced drought now face the additional burden of toxic atmospheric pollution. For rural farmers, contaminated water and degraded soil threaten not only food production but the survival of entire local economies.

Agricultural scientists caution that sulfur deposition can alter soil chemistry for years, significantly reducing crop productivity. Staples such as wheat and barley, along with fruit orchards, could suffer severe yield losses. In a region already struggling with food insecurity due to climate change and political instability, this new environmental threat may deepen hunger and poverty.

Despite the fact that global institutions have repeatedly emphasised the need for coordinated monitoring systems and cross-border environmental governance, environmental disasters rarely respect political borders. Toxic plumes drifting across continents demonstrate how deeply interconnected ecological systems truly are. When ecosystems collapse in one region, the consequences inevitably ripple across others.

Encouragingly, some diplomatic efforts continue. On March 16, 2026, Pope Leo XIV held a telephone conversation with Mahmoud Abbas, President of the Palestinian Authority, to discuss what the Vatican described as the "alarming developments in the Middle East." The Holy See reaffirmed its commitment to promoting peace through dialogue and respect for international law. While symbolic, such moral voices remain essential reminders that diplomacy must ultimately prevail over destruction.

Scientists often note that environmental crises rarely begin with dramatic events. They emerge gradually—through a haze in the sky, a decline in crop yields, or unexplained illnesses in vulnerable communities. When such warnings are ignored, the consequences can escalate into full-scale humanitarian disasters.

The unfolding tragedy in West Asia is therefore more than a regional conflict. It is a stark reminder of the dangers of pursuing absolute victory in a deeply interconnected world. In an age where warfare can destabilise not only governments but entire ecosystems, the true cost of power is measured not merely in military victories, but in the lives, landscapes, and futures that are lost along the way.

Views expressed are personal

REMAINED TO NIA CUSTODY

‘Anti-India’ conspiracy: Phones of 7 foreigners sent for data extraction

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Security agencies have sent mobile phones of seven arrested foreign nationals, including a self-styled US mercenary, for forensic data extraction as part of an expanding probe into an alleged conspiracy to undermine India's national security, officials said on Thursday.

Investigators are also scanning the social media accounts of the accused—six of whom are Ukrainian nationals—to trace funding sources, identify the mastermind, and map their network of associates. The arrests were carried out by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) after the group was initially intercepted by the Bureau of Immigration at multiple airports while attempting to transit through the country.

According to the NIA's FIR, a total of 14 Ukrainian nationals had entered India on tourist visas over a period of time and travelled to Guwahati and Mizoram without the mandatory Restricted/Protected Area Permits. From there, they allegedly crossed into Myanmar illegally to conduct pre-arranged training sessions for Ethnic Armed Groups (EAGs).

These groups are believed to have links with insurgent outfits operating in India and are suspected of receiving training in drone warfare and jamming technologies. Officials said such support could significantly enhance the operational capabilities of anti-India groups.

Among those arrested is Matthew Aaron VanDyke, detained at Kolkata airport. VanDyke, founder of the security organisation “Sons



Foreign nationals, accused of illegally entering Mizoram, then Myanmar, to contact and train ethnic war groups, being taken away from Patila House Court on Monday

Ukraine calls for ‘transparent’ probe

NEW DELHI: Days after six Ukrainian nationals were detained by Indian authorities, Ukraine on Thursday called for a transparent investigation into the case and expressed readiness to cooperate in the probe.

At the same time, Ukraine said it “firmly rejects any insinuations regarding the possible involvement of the Ukrainian state in supporting terrorist activities” in India.

External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in his weekly media briefing that relevant agencies of the government are investigating the case.

He said New Delhi has received a request for consular access to the Ukrainian nationals and a decision will be taken keeping in mind the legal requirements.

Ukraine's ambassador Olek-

sandr Polishchuk had met Secretary (West) in the External Affairs Ministry, Sibi George, this week and sought consular access to the Ukrainians.

The embassy of Ukraine on Thursday took strong note of media reports indicating that the initiation of action in the case was “prompted” by information provided by the Russian side.

In a statement, the mission expressed its “serious concern” over what it claimed as the “presence of circumstances that point to a possible orchestrated and politically motivated nature of this case, as evidenced, in particular, by the facts known at this stage”. “Ukraine firmly rejects any insinuations regarding the possible involvement of the Ukrainian state in supporting terrorist activities,” it said. MPOST

of Liberty International”, has reportedly been involved in conflict zones globally.

The other accused—Hurba Petro, Sliyviak Taras, Ivan Suk-

manovskiy, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim, and Kaminskyi Viktor—were detained from Delhi and Lucknow airports.

Multi-crore bank fraud cases: CBI quizzes Anil Ambani, Amit Dangi

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) questioned Anil Ambani for nearly eight hours on Thursday regarding a Rs 2,929.05 crore bank fraud case tied to Reliance Communications Limited.

The case was registered on August 21, 2025, after a complaint from the State Bank of India, which leads a group of 11 lenders. The CBI states that the complaint stems from a forensic audit report. This report claims that there was significant diversion and misuse of loan funds through linked transactions among associated companies from 2013 to 2017. The alleged fraud resulted in a loss of Rs 2,929.05 crore to SBI out of a total of Rs 19,694.33 crore across 17 public sector banks.

Following this, multiple banks, including Punjab National Bank, Bank of India, Union Bank of India, UCO Bank, Central Bank of India, IDBI Bank, and Bank of Maharashtra, submitted separate complaints. In February and March 2026, the agency registered additional cases based on complaints from Bank of Baroda and Punjab National Bank, naming additional suspects including Manjari Ashok Kacker.

Earlier, on August 23, 2025, the CBI searched official and residential locations of Reliance Communications and Anil Ambani in Mumbai, recovering several incriminating documents.

In a separate but related matter, the agency also questioned Amit Dangi for about

seven hours. This inquiry concerned a Rs 57.47 crore fraud case linked to Reliance Commercial Finance Limited. Dangi serves as a Whole-Time Director at Authum Investment and Infrastructure Limited, which has acquired assets from Reliance Commercial Finance Ltd and Reliance Home Finance Limited.

This case was registered on December 6, 2025, following a complaint from the Bank of Maharashtra, which accused them of causing a wrongful loss of Rs 57.47 crore. Investigators noted that the forensic audit report indicated significant fund diversion.

In December 2025, searches were carried out at locations in Mumbai and Pune, resulting in the seizure of several incriminating documents.

PREZ INSTALLS SHRI RAM YANTRA AT AYODHYA TEMPLE

Witnessing construction of Ram Temple a ‘moment of pride’ for nation: Prez Murmu

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: President Droupadi Murmu visited the Ram Temple in Ayodhya on the first day of Navratri and offered prayers to Lord Ram. She also installed the Shri Ram Yantra at the Ram Darbar on the second floor of the temple complex and reviewed the ongoing development works at the site.

The President arrived at Ayodhya airport at around 10.30 am from Delhi and was received by Uttar Pradesh Governor Anandiben Patel and Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath. She later proceeded to the temple, where the Chief Minister briefed her on the progress of construction and associated works.

Calling the visit deeply significant, the President said it was a matter of great fortune to set foot on the sacred land believed to be the birthplace of Lord Ram. She said Ayodhya holds a special place for millions of devotees and noted that Lord Ram had described his birthplace as greater than heaven.



President Droupadi Murmu offers prayers at the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple, in Ayodhya

Murmu also referred to artistic depictions of Lord Ram's return to Ayodhya after the victory over Lanka, noting that such scenes are reflected in the Constitution. She said witnessing the construction of the Ram Temple is a moment of pride for the nation and recalled that she had written to the Prime Minister during the consecration ceremony, describing it as a historic occasion for all citizens.

Expressing confidence about India's future, the President said the country is steadily moving

towards becoming a developed nation and could achieve its goals by 2040 or earlier. She added that the vision of an ideal welfare state as described in the Ramayana continues to guide the nation's progress.

Highlighting the historical importance of the temple, she said the consecration and related ceremonies mark a landmark moment after centuries of struggle. She described the installation of the Shri Ram Yantra as a symbol of divine grace.

KEY POINTS

- » Calling the visit deeply significant, the President said it was a matter of great fortune to set foot on the sacred land believed to be the birthplace of Lord Ram
- » She said the country is steadily moving towards becoming a developed nation and could achieve its goals by 2040 or earlier

‘Snake venom’ case: SC quashes FIR and proceedings against Elvish Yadav

YouTuber welcomes verdict; asks ‘who will compensate for harassment we faced’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday quashed an FIR and subsequent proceedings against YouTuber Elvish Yadav, who was arrested for allegedly using snake venom at a rave party in Noida, Uttar Pradesh, in 2023, and said the case cannot be sustained in law.

A bench of Justices M M Sundresh and N Kotiswar Singh said it was confining its consideration to two specific questions -- the applicability of Section 2(23) of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985, and the validity of proceedings under Section 55 of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972.

The top court, however, granted liberty to the competent authority to initiate appropriate proceedings in accordance with law by filing a proper complaint under Sec-



tion 55 of the Wildlife Protection Act.

The case against Yadav was registered on November 22, 2023, and he was arrested on March 17, 2024.

The apex court said offences under the Indian Penal Code (IPC) invoked in the FIR against Yadav were based on an earlier FIR registered in Gurugram, in which a closure report has been filed.

The bench noted that

no recovery had been made from Yadav himself, with the chargesheet only alleging that he placed orders for snake venom for recreational purposes through his friends, who are co-accused in the case.

It said provisions of the NDPS Act cannot be invoked as the liquid substance recovered from the co-accused was not a prescribed substance under the schedule.

On the invocation of the Wildlife Protection Act, the top court said Section 55 mandates that prosecution can be initiated only through a complaint filed by a duly authorised officer.

In the case in hand, it noted, the complainant was a former employee of Wildlife Board of India and therefore not an authorised person under the Act to lodge a complaint.

The bench referred to the earlier decisions of the court and said the case against Yadav

cannot be sustained in law. It quashed the FIR and subsequent proceedings, including filing of the chargesheet and cognisance order of the trial court.

The controversial YouTuber had challenged an Allahabad High Court order refusing to quash the chargesheet and the cognisance order of the trial court terminating it a serious offence.

Yadav expressed happiness over the verdict, saying he always had faith in the judiciary. However, he asked who would compensate for the harassment he and his family faced.

Yadav said he was relieved after the case was quashed and described himself as “free”.

“The media ran continuous reports claiming I was guilty. My family faced immense harassment. For over two-and-a-half years, there was a stigma attached to my name and my family suffered greatly,” he said.

HP Assembly passes supplementary Budget exceeding Rs 40,461 crore

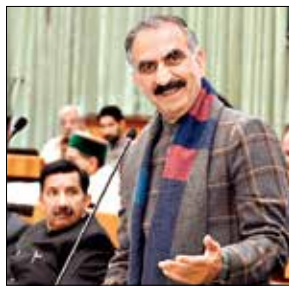
ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: The Himachal Pradesh Assembly voted a record Rs 40,461 crore supplementary Budget for the current financial year 2025-26 in a swift move that even surprised the Opposition BJP.

This was the first time a supplementary Budget of such a high amount was presented in the House, in addition to the already passed Rs 52,709 crore Budget of the state.

The Opposition did not extend any argument on the supplementary Budget, as it was passed by voice vote.

The supplementary Budget included Rs 36,374.61 crore under state schemes and Rs 4,087.34 crore for centrally



sponsored schemes.

The breakup shows Rs 26,194.95 crore allocated as ‘Ways and Means’—salaries and pensions and also over-draft—while Rs 4,150.14 crore has been earmarked for power generation.

Another Rs 818.20 crore will be for natural disaster relief, Rs 785.22 crore

for water supply and sewerage schemes, and Rs 657.22 crore for Himcare, the Sahara Scheme, robotic surgery facilities at the medical colleges, and other expenditures in the health sector.

Under the Special Central Assistance, Rs 555.89 crore has been earmarked for projects, including shopping complexes at the vegetable market, bus stand, flyover, and underground utility duct in Shimla town.

Chief Minister Sukhinder Singh Sukhu is slated to present the state's annual Budget for the next financial year of 2026-27 on Saturday, which is going to be a tightrope walk in view of the fiscal crisis and withdrawal of the RDG by the Centre.

MPOST

RS polls: Haryana Cong accuses BJP of horse-trading

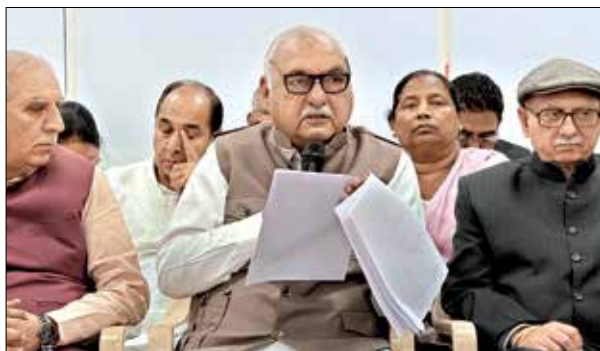
CHANDIGARH: A Congress delegation met Haryana Governor Ashim Kumar Ghosh here on Thursday, alleging that the ruling BJP behaved as “political predators” and openly indulged in horse-trading in the recently held Rajya Sabha polls in the state.

The delegation under the Haryana Congress Legislature Party was led by Leader of Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda.

The Congress also alleged that the role of the Returning Officer, IAS Pankaj Aggarwal, was partisan.

The Congress memorandum submitted to the governor said: “The ruling dispensation behaved as ‘political predators’ and adopted all immoral means for the victory of the independent candidate.”

The ruling BJP openly indulged in horse-trading, Faustian bargains, intimidations,



Haryana LoP Bhupinder Singh Hooda leads the Congress delegation during a meeting with Governor Ashim Kumar Ghosh

tions, institutional pressures, dishonest deals and misuse of government machinery, it added.

The Congress Legislature Party has requested the governor, in his capacity as the constitutional guardian of the state, to order an inquiry into this unethical and undemocratic conduct, to direct the govern-

ment to uphold democratic values, decency, and discipline.

The polling for two Rajya Sabha seats was held here on Monday, in which BJP's Sanjay Bhatia won one seat, while Congress candidate Karamvir Singh Boudh secured the other in a close contest against Independent candidate Satish Nandal.

Haryana BJP's vice-president, Nandal, had contested the elections as an Independent candidate.

Boudh's victory by a narrow margin came amid allegations that five Congress candidates allegedly cross-voted. Besides, of the five votes declared invalid, four were reportedly cast by Congress legislators.

According to the memorandum, given the numerical strength both parties enjoy in the 90-member Assembly -- BJP (48) and Congress (37) -- under normal circumstances, the victory of both candidates of BJP and Congress was a foregone conclusion.

Despite the lack of requisite members for winning the second seat, the BJP propped up Nandal, proposed by three Independent MLAs and 7 BJP MLAs, as an independent candidate.

MPOST

BUREAUCRATIC REJIG

Hry govt transfers 23 IAS officers

CHANDIGARH: In a major administrative reshuffle, the Haryana government on Thursday transferred 23 Indian Administrative Service officers with immediate effect.

According to an official statement, Raja Sekhar Vundru, additional chief secretary of food, civil supplies and consumer affairs department, has been posted as additional chief secretary of printing and stationery department.

G Anupama, additional chief secretary of citizen resources information department, will now serve as additional chief secretary of civil aviation department.

Apoorva Kumar Singh, additional chief secretary of town and country planning and urban estates department, has been posted as additional chief secretary of higher education department, as well as public works (buildings and roads) and architecture department.

Anurag Agarwal, additional chief secretary for public works (buildings and roads) and architecture, and advisor to the Haryana Saraswati Heritage Board, has been posted as additional chief secretary for town and country planning and urban estates department.

INSIGHT

» Raja Sekhar Vundru, additional chief secretary of food, civil supplies and consumer affairs department, has been posted as additional chief

secretary of printing and stationery department

» G Anupama, additional chief secretary of citizen resources information department, will now serve as additional chief secretary of civil aviation department

administration departments and chief executive officer of Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority, has been posted as chief executive officer of Faridabad Metropolitan Development Authority, in addition to his present duties.

A Mona Sreenivas, additional resident commissioner at Haryana Bhawan in New Delhi, has been posted as resident commissioner at Haryana Bhawana.

Mani Ram Sharma, managing director of Uttar Haryana Bijli Vitran Nigam Limited and secretary of energy department, has been posted as registrar for cooperative societies.

Sushil Sarwan, deputy commissioner of Sonipat, has been posted as managing director for Haryana State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation as well as Haryana Financial Corporation.

MPOST

INCREASES NUMBER OF WOMEN HOPEFULS TO SIX

BJP unveils 88 candidates for Assam polls; Sarma to contest from Jalukbari

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GUWAHATI/NEW DELHI: The BJP on Thursday released its first list of 88 candidates for the Assam Assembly polls, fielding Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma from Jalukbari seat.

Sarma contested from Jalukbari constituency in a bid to retain it for the sixth consecutive term.

Sitting BJP MP Hiten-dra Nath Goswami has been fielded against state Congress chief Gaurav Gogoi from Jorhat.

Congress leaders Pradyut Bordoloi and Bhupen Borah, who recently joined the BJP, will contest from Dispur and Bihpuria, respectively.

Among other recent entrants from the Congress, Sashi Kanta Das has been fielded from Raha (SC), while Kamalakhyia Purkayastha has been shifted from Karimganj (North) to Katigorah.



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma with BJP president Dilip Saikia during a meeting at the party office, in Guwahati, on Thursday

Former AGP MLA Bhupen Roy, who recently joined the BJP, will contest from Abhayapuri.

Cabinet ministers who will contest from their current seats are Ajanta Neog from Golaghat, Education minister Ranoj Pegu

from Dhemaji (ST), Rupesh Gowala from Doomdoo, Binal Borah from Tingkhon, Pijush Hazarika from Jagiroad (SC), Jayanta Malla Baruah from Nalbari, Ashok Singhal from Dhekiajuli, Krishendu Paul from Patharkandi and

Highlights

» Congress leaders Pradyut Bordoloi and Bhupen Borah, who recently joined the BJP, will contest from Dispur and Bihpuria, respectively

» The party has also given tickets to 27 other sitting MLAs from their respective seats

» Sitting BJP MP Hiten-dra Nath Goswami has been fielded against state Congress chief Gaurav Gogoi from Jorhat

Kaushik Rai from Lakhipur.

Among those whose constituencies have been changed are Speaker Biswajit Daimary, shifted from Panery to Tamulpur (ST), and ministers Chandramohan Patowary (Dharmapur to Tihu) and Ran-

jeet Kumar Dass (Pathacharkuchi to Bhawanipur-Sorbhog).

Sports minister Nandita Garlosa, representing Haflong (ST), has been replaced by Rupali Langthasa, while Deputy speaker Numal Momin, representing Bokajan (ST), has been replaced by Surjya Rongphar.

Former Union minister Rameshwar Teli will contest from Dulaijan, a seat currently represented by Terash Gowala, who has been elected to the Rajya Sabha. The Mahmora seat, represented by minister Jogen Mohan, also recently elected to the Rajya Sabha, has been given to Suruj Dihingia.

Former minister and state BJP president Bhabesh Kalita will contest from Rangia, while Sajay Kishan has been shifted from Tinsukia to Makum.

The party has increased the number of women candidates to six from two in the previous elections.

Tharoor sides with govt's 'cautious stand' on Iran war

Cong's Manish Tewari also supports India's cautious approach

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Senior Congress leader Shashi Tharoor on Thursday said he understands the Indian government's desire to take a cautious stand on the conflict between US-Israel and Iran, and hoped that it could make a public call to both sides to end the war quickly.

The former minister of state for external affairs also stated that the government should have immediately offered public condolences to Iran over the death of its former supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and acted on similar lines as it had done in the aftermath of the demise of then Iranian president Ebrahim Raisi in a helicopter crash in 2024.

Tharoor asserted that in the current circumstances, a good group of countries not party to the conflict on either side could go to both sides and ask them to call off the conflict, and India should be at the forefront of this.



Shashi Tharoor also said India should push for peace

Asked about assertions from various quarters that India should have condemned the assassination of Khamenei in a US-Israel strike, Tharoor said, "I don't know about condemning it, but we should certainly have condoled it. After all (he was) the spiritual leader of a country with which he has friendly relations. It would have been appropriate, the day it happened, for us to express public condolences and share the grief of his loved ones and of his nation just as two years ago when president Raisi was killed in a helicopter crash, we immediately issued a con-

dolence as well as announced national mourning."

Tharoor noted that the moment the Iranian embassy opened the condolence book, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri went and signed the book, which was a "good thing", he said. "But I guess we could have been a bit more... it is simply the courteous thing to do for any country," Tharoor said.

"But apart from that, I think I understand the government's desire to take, for the lack of a better word, a cautious stand," he said.

Meanwhile, Congress' Manish Tewari also supported the government's cautious approach, saying India has limited stakes in West Asia and should be careful in its positioning. He noted that the region isn't a single conflict but multiple overlapping wars, adding that the Iran-Israel-US situation is complex. "It's not our war," he said, emphasising that India has largely been a marginal player in the region.

Cong says education Bill violates federal structure, raises 7 'concerns'

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Thursday expressed serious concerns over the new Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, alleging that the proposed law was violative of the federal structure of the Constitution.

In a statement, Congress general secretary, communications, Jairam Ramesh listed seven key issues the Congress has with the Bill in its present form, which include failure to consult state governments while framing it, constitutional overreach, absence of funding council, bureaucratisation of higher education and dilution of UGC's Consultative requirements.

The Congress has alleged that the architecture of higher education is sought to be "restructured" through the Bill, which is currently under consid-

Alleges that the architecture of higher education is being "restructured" through the Bill

eration of the Joint Committee of Parliament. "The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education's annual Demand for Grants report on the Department of Higher Education presented yesterday revealed a shockingly high number of vacancies in key regulatory agencies like the UGC and the All India Council for Technical Education. "This concerning news comes at a time when there is already a move to restructure the architecture of higher edu-

cation regulation through the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, 2025," he said.

Ramesh claimed that the ministry has not consulted state governments in the drafting of this bill, despite the fact that education is listed in the Concurrent List of the Constitution and this Bill directly impacts state universities.

He said that the proposed Bill, as stated in its Statement of Objects and Reasons, is introduced for passing in Parliament under Entry 66 of Union List in the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution, which gives specific legislative powers to Parliament that is only for "co-ordination and determination of standards in institutions for higher education or research."

CIC flags Aadhaar update delays

NEW DELHI: The Central Information Commission (CIC) has flagged delays in updating Aadhaar details and asked the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) to fix timelines and strengthen its grievance redressal system.

The observations came while disposing of an appeal filed by a woman who had sought correction of date of birth in her Aadhaar card, alleging that her request was not processed in time.

During the hearing, the appellant said that despite submitting the required documents, her request remained pending for a long time, forcing her to approach the Delhi High Court by filing a writ petition in the matter.

Tribal chiefs meet Rahul, express concern over Great Nicobar Project

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday met a delegation of tribal chiefs from the Great Nicobar Island and discussed their opposition to the proposed Great Nicobar Project.

"The chiefs expressed strong opposition to the proposed Great Nicobar project, stating that it poses a serious threat to their way of life and the island's fragile ecosystem," the Congress said on X after the meeting.

"They also highlighted that their consent was not properly obtained during the approval process," the party said, sharing pictures of the meeting at Gandhi's residence.

The tribal chiefs were accompanied by leaders of the Adivasi Congress.

The party said Gandhi



Rahul Gandhi with a delegation of tribal chiefs from Great Nicobar Island, in New Delhi, on Thursday

assured the delegation that the Congress would stand by them and raise their concerns to safeguard their rights and interests.

The Congress has termed the Great Nicobar Project a threat to the ecology and has been opposing it.

Meanwhile, The government is steadfastly working towards bridging the gap between tribal producers and

JD(U) MLA Anant Singh gets bail in murder case

PATNA: The Patna High Court on Thursday granted bail to JD(U) MLA Anant Singh in connection with the murder of Dular Chand Yadav during the campaign trail for the Bihar elections last year.

Singh, who was arrested on November 1, was accused of orchestrating the killing.

He won the elections from Mokama from behind bars, defeating Veena Singh of RJD by over 28,000 votes.

A bench of Justice Rudra Prakash Mishra granted him bail on a bond of Rs 15,000.

"The petitioner will not tamper with the prosecution evidence or influence/intimidate any witness during the course of the trial," the court said.

Yadav was supporting the candidate of Prashant Kishor's Jan Suraj Party in the elections. His post-mortem report stated that he died of cardiorespiratory failure due to shock caused by injury to the heart and lungs by a hard and blunt substance.

Mokama assembly seat has remained with Singh's family since 1990, regardless of party affiliation, except for a brief interlude during which it was wrested by a rival "baahubali".

Singh gave the mantle to his wife Neelam Devi in 2022, when his conviction in a UAPA case led to his disqualification from the assembly. He was acquitted by the high court in the case.

Barricades & broken promises: Inside Vijay's TVK Iftaar chaos

MAMALLAPURAM: A buzzing Iftaar organised by TVK and busloads of cadres flipped the script for the sleepy coastal town of Poonjeri near Mahabalipuram on March 18 evening.

It is obvious that Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), still reeling from the near-mythical chaos of its inaugural Iftaar held at the YMCA grounds in Royapettah, bang in the middle of Chennai, hoped that this nondescript town in the middle of nowhere, would absorb the frenzy of the fans-turned-cadres.

The inaugural event had turned into a logistical nightmare for the police.

Party cadres noted that the second iteration was significantly more organised than the Chennai debut, a shift partially attributed to the choice of venue and the ample parking space.

Not willing to take a chance, Aadhav Arjuna, general secretary of TVK's election campaign management, had also spent a considerable time schooling those seated for Iftaar on how they should behave: "Don't get up from your seats; pay respect to the occasion; if you have a phone on you -- they were expected to leave the phones outside -- don't take it out to make selfies or reels."

All that worked to an extent. As long as Vijay prayed, the crowd prayed too. But as the actor was about to leave, a frenzy gripped the crowd and people started pushing each other to get close to him.

Things were not that different in the separate enclosure that seated women and children. The women could barely contain themselves and all wanted to take a spot near the opening of the enclosure. Saira, a fan-turned-cadre from Villupuram, who attended both the events, recalled that during the previous year's gathering, the enthusiasm to see "Thalapathy" was so intense that women tore down the barricades separating them from the men's section.

RS poll jolt exposes fault lines in Grand Alliance

PATNA: A blame game was on within the Mahagathbandhan in Bihar, days after four MLAs of the opposition coalition failed to turn up for voting in biennial Rajya Sabha elections, resulting in a walkover for the ruling NDA.

Although the 35 MLA-strong multi-party coalition got the support of five legislators of the AIMIM and one of the BSP, its candidate Amarendra Dhari Singh failed to get re-elected for a second consecutive term, and the defeat is being blamed on the absence of three MLAs of the Congress and one of the RJD.

An embarrassed Congress, which has only six MLAs in the state assembly, has shot off notices to its absentee MLAs -- Manoj Biswas, Surendra Kush-

Congress issues show-cause notices to four Haryana MLAs

CHANDIGARH: The Congress has issued show-cause notices to four of its Haryana MLAs who allegedly cross-voted during the Rajya Sabha elections on Monday. The action comes after the party's disclosure on Wednesday naming four of five legislators suspected of defying the official line. The name of the fifth MLA remains undisclosed. "We have served show-cause notices to the four party MLAs," Dharampal Malik, Chairman of the state Congress disciplinary committee, said.

waha and Manohar Prasad -- seeking an explanation on why they did not vote in favour of Singh on March 16. The notice was issued on Wednesday by Kapil Deo Prasad Yadav, the head of the state Congress disciplinary committee.

Biswas, who spoke to

reporters after the receipt of the notice, stuck to his guns and said, "I have drafted my reply. I had indulged in no indiscipline. I did not cross-vote. The candidate fielded by the RJD was not to my liking. No diktat was issued by the state leadership to vote in favour of Ama-

rendra Dhari Singh, so I acted as per my conscience. My party was not being treated with respect by the RJD."

Biswas also claimed that he would have voted in favour of the RJD candidate had the party fielded a Muslim, a community which has a formidable presence in his assembly constituency of Forbesganj.

"Till the eleventh hour, it was being said that the RJD was going to field Hina Shahab. I wonder what changed," said Biswas, referring to the widow of gangster-turned-politician Mohd Shahabuddin, a multiple-term former MLA from Siwan, whose son Osama is the MLA from Raghunathpur.

Kushwaha said he had reservations about "voting for a Bhumihar candidate".

One-third of Rajya Sabha MPs face criminal cases; 14% are billionaires, says ADR report

Over 70 Rajya Sabha MPs with criminal cases, 31 billionaires are in the mix

NEW DELHI: Around 32 per cent of sitting Rajya Sabha MPs have declared criminal cases against themselves, while 14 per cent are billionaires, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR).

The report is based on an analysis of affidavits of 229 out of 233 Rajya Sabha MPs. One seat from Jharkhand is currently vacant, while affidavits of three MPs were not available. The analysis includes 37 recently elected members.

Of the 229 MPs analysed, 73 (32 per cent) have declared criminal cases. Among them, 36 (16 per cent) face serious criminal charges. The report highlights that one MP has declared a case of murder, four MPs have cases related to attempted murder, and three MPs face charges connected to crimes against women.

Party-wise data shows that criminal cases are spread across major political formations. Among BJP MPs, 27 out of 99 have declared criminal cases. In the Congress, 12 out of 28 MPs



MPs pose for a group photograph with retiring and recently retired members of the Rajya Sabha

Key Points

» 73 MPs have declared criminal cases, including 36 (16%) facing serious charges such as murder and crimes against women. One MP has declared 36 serious cases

» Among major parties,

the BJP leads with 27 of 99 MPs declaring criminal cases, followed by Congress (12 of 28), TMC (4 of 13), and AAP (4 of 10). Wealth concentration is evident, with one BRS MP declaring over ₹5,300 crore in assets, the highest report

have such cases, while four of 13 TMC MPs and four of 10 AAP MPs have also disclosed criminal cases. Additionally,

three MPs each from CPI(M) and BRS have declared criminal cases.

The report also sheds light

on the financial profiles of Rajya Sabha members. It finds that 31 MPs, accounting for 14 per cent of the total analysed, have declared net worth in the range of billions of rupees. This indicates a significant concentration of wealth among a section of lawmakers in the Upper House.

Among major parties, several MPs have declared assets exceeding Rs 100 crore. These include six BJP MPs, five Congress MPs, four YSRCP MPs, two AAP MPs, two BRS MPs, and three NCP MPs. The report notes that such high-value asset

declarations are present across multiple parties, reflecting a broader trend rather than being confined to any single political group.

The average assets of a Rajya Sabha MP stand at Rs 120.69 crore, according to the ADR analysis. Party-wise averages vary significantly. BJP MPs have an average asset value of Rs 28.29 crore, while Congress MPs average Rs 128.61 crore. TMC MPs have average assets of Rs 17.70 crore, whereas AAP MPs show a much higher average of Rs 574.09 crore. Other parties include YSRCP with Rs 522.63 crore, SP with Rs 399.71 crore, BJD with Rs 105.63 crore, and DMK with Rs 11.90 crore.

The report also identifies the wealthiest members in the Rajya Sabha. BRS MP Bandi Partha Saradhi tops the list with declared assets exceeding Rs 5,300 crore. He is followed by AAP's Rajinder Gupta, who has declared assets of over Rs 5,053 crore, and YSRCP's Alla Ayodhya Rami Reddy with assets worth more than Rs 2,577 crore.

Nation Briefs

K SUDHAKARAN SAYS WON'T CONTEST WITHOUT PARTY PERMISSION

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM/NEW DELHI: Congress MP and party strongman K Sudhakaran on Thursday said that he will not be contesting in the upcoming Assembly polls in Kerala without the party's backing. Sudhakaran also ended speculation about him leaving the Congress to form another party or join some other political front, saying "where will I go?" "The party has not pushed me out. It only denied me a seat. I will stay and work for the party. I am no one to challenge it as the party is so much bigger and I am so small. "I will accept the party's decision," the MP from Kannur told reporters as he left his accommodation in New Delhi for the airport to return to Kerala.

CONGRESS SLAMS GOVT OVER SOCIAL MEDIA 'CRACKDOWN'

NEW DELHI: The Congress slammed the BJP-led Centre on Thursday for its "crackdown" on social media, including X, YouTube and Instagram, by allegedly ordering the closure of several accounts and said undermining free speech is a threat to democracy. Addressing a press conference here, Congress spokesperson and the head of the party's social media and digital platforms wing, Supriya Shrinete, claimed that multiple accounts across various social media platforms have either been blocked or restricted under official directives. She alleged that the government led by PM Narendra Modi is trying to suppress dissent and evade accountability by curbing digital expression.

BHARAT ELECTRICITY SUMMIT 2026

PM invites global investors to invest in power sector

‘India stands at a defining moment in its energy journey as world’s fastest-growing major economy,’ Modi said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday invited global investors to invest in the power sector, urging them to “make, invest, innovate, and scale” in India.

In a written message read out by Union Power Secretary Pankaj Aggarwal at the Bharat Electricity Summit 2026, Modi said India stands at a defining moment in its energy journey as the world’s fastest-growing major economy.

“I invite the global community to make in India, innovate in India, invest in India, and scale with India. I’m confident this summit will catalyse meaningful dialogue and enduring partnerships to power India’s growth,” Modi said.

Modi said the summit aims to bring the whole power and energy ecosystem onto a single platform to exchange ideas, foster collaboration, and chart a shared path to power growth and improve life.

“It reflects our collective resolve of electrifying growth



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

‘I’m confident this summit will catalyse meaningful dialogue and enduring partnerships to power India’s growth,’ Modi said

and bringing sustainability, connecting globally, and advances India’s vision of a Viksit Bharat by 2047,” he stated.

India stands at a defining movement in its energy journey, as the words fastest-growing major economy, we are

Highlights

- » ‘The summit aims to bring the whole power and energy ecosystem onto a single platform to exchange ideas, foster collaboration’
- » Over 50 per cent non-fossil fuel capacity has already been achieved, with a clear pathway to 500 gigawatt by 2030, he noted
- » Initiatives like one sun, one world, one grid underscore our vision for global cooperation, the prime minister pointed out

strengthening infrastructure and ensuring reliable energy access for all, he noted.

Our renewable energy progress is a testimony to this commitment. Over 50 per cent non-fossil fuel capacity has already been achieved, with a

clear pathway to 500 gigawatt by 2030, he noted.

Initiatives like one sun, one world, one grid underscore our vision for global cooperation, he pointed out.

India is evolving into a reliable energy partner in building resilient supply chains, advancing battery manufacturing, creating green jobs, and enabling investments through bold reforms, Modi added.

The SHANTI Act 2025 opens new frontiers in nuclear energy, while PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana is driving distributed generation and sustainable consumption, he noted.

Reforms and distribution are equally significant in reducing AT&C losses and improving finances in 2024-25, signalling a more efficient and sustainable sector with vast opportunities across the value chain, making India a compelling destination to invest in weight and scale, the Prime Minister said in his written message.

The four-day Bharat Electricity Summit 2026 began on Thursday.

India took swift steps to safeguard nation’s maritime trade: Sonowal

MUMBAI: India has taken swift and coordinated measures to safeguard the country’s maritime trade amid the evolving situation in West Asia to ensure seamless cargo movement and minimal disruption to supply chains, Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal said on Thursday.

Chairing a review and consultation meeting with stakeholders, Sonowal, who is the Minister for Ports, Shipping and Waterways, said that the country’s maritime sector continues to stand strong, responsive, and fully equipped to handle global uncertainties while supporting its economic momentum, an official release said.

“The Ministry has taken swift and coordinated measures to safeguard the nation’s maritime trade amid the evolving situation in the Middle East. Our ports have demonstrated resilience and capability in responding to emerging chal-

‘The country’s maritime sector continues to stand strong, responsive, and fully equipped to handle global uncertainties’

lenges,” Sonowal said. These measures have been taken through efficient handling of diverted vessels along the Western coast, humanitarian assistance extended to international crew, or proactive trade facilitation measures implemented at key ports such as Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority, he said.

The meeting brought together representatives from shipping lines, terminal operators, and trade bodies to deliberate on emerging challenges, including potential disruptions in shipping routes, vessel sched-

ules, and cargo flows. The discussions focused on ensuring continuity of operations, minimizing delays, and maintaining supply chain resilience, it said.

Stakeholders shared on-ground insights and highlighted the measures being undertaken to manage evolving conditions, particularly with respect to export-import cargo movements to and from Middle East destinations, the release stated.

“We remain in constant coordination with all stakeholders, ensuring real-time monitoring, seamless cargo movement, and minimal disruption to supply chains. India’s maritime sector continues to stand strong, responsive, and fully equipped to handle global uncertainties while supporting the nation’s economic momentum.”

India has sought to reassure global markets that its maritime trade remains stable and resilient despite ongoing tensions in the Middle East, it stated.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Natarajan Chandrasekaran, Chairman, Tata Group, was presented the insignia of the Knight Commander of the Most Excellent Order of the British Empire (KBE) on 18 March for services to UK-India business relations. The Tata Group is a long-standing investor in the UK with operations spanning automotive, steel, technology, and consumer sectors. The presentation ceremony was held in the presence of his friends and family at the British High Commissioner’s residence in New Delhi. As Chairman of Tata Group, he has made an exceptional contribution to UK-India business relations and to investing in the UK over many years.



NTPC Limited signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Octopus Energy Group to explore strategic collaboration across the power and energy sector. The MoU was signed on the side lines of Bharat Electricity Summit 2026, being held from 19-22 March 2026, under the aegis of Ministry of Power, Government of India in the presence of Pankaj Aggarwal, Secretary (Ministry of Power, GoI), Piyush Singh, Additional Secretary (Ministry of Power, GoI), Gurdeep Singh, CMD, NTPC Limited and Renu Narang, CEO, NVVN. The MoU was signed by Dr. Jatinder Singh Chandok, Head International Business Development, NTPC and Chris Fitzgerald, Group Director, International Affairs, Octopus Energy.

India well prepared to meet 270 GW peak power demand: Manohar Lal

‘We always keep an eye on our peak demand. Our peak demand, that is, the maximum amount of power we need at any given time,’ the minister said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India is well prepared to meet the projected peak power demand of 270 GW during this summer season, Union Power Minister Manohar Lal said on Thursday.

The statement assumes significance in view of the ongoing West Asia crisis, when the use of electric appliances like induction cookers, as well as electric vehicles, is likely to increase in the country. Addressing Bharat Electricity Summit 2026, the minister said, “We always keep an eye on our peak demand. Our peak demand, that is, the maximum amount of power we need at any given time.”

Two years ago, in FY25, India had a peak demand of 250 GW. In FY26, the power ministry had set a higher target of 270 GW, but due to weather conditions, peak demand did not increase to estimated levels, he added. “This time too, we’ve made preparations that if we need to supply up to 270 GW of power this May-June, then we are prepared. There’s no problem whatsoever,” he said. About the power demand, the minister stated that this is only going to increase in the future as the era of AI dawns, data centres are built, and EVs are being used.



About the power demand, the minister stated that this is only going to increase in the future as the era of AI dawns, data centres are built, and EVs are being used

As we progress in all these areas, we’ll need at least 30 GW for these tasks over the next 5-6 years. At that time, our target of 300 GW (peak power demand) will be reached on its own, he pointed out. About the power transmission infrastructure in the country, he states that by 2034, India will complete a 900 GW transmission line.

As far as energy, i.e., transmission, is concerned, he noted that India has added 2.09 lakh circuit km of lines to the net-

work in the last 10 years, representing a 72 per cent increase.

“Our network is emerging as one of the strongest in the world, which will benefit us in the future,” he added. Earlier this month, Minister of State for Power Shripad Yesso Naik said that the peak power demand is projected to be around 270 GW this summer and there will be no effect on regular electricity supply due to the West Asia crisis.

The Power Ministry had

India needs \$2 trillion investment in power sector over next 2 decades: Power Secretary

NEW DELHI: India will require investment of about \$2.2 trillion in the power sector over the next two decades, a senior official said on Thursday.

India has set a target of 500 GW of renewable energy by 2030 and the addition of 97 GW of coal-based thermal power generation capacity by 2034-35.

The transition ahead will require unprecedented investment. India will require an investment of about \$2.2 trillion over the next two decades, Union Power Secretary Pankaj Aggarwal said, addressing the Bharat Electricity Summit 2026.

India has made a lot of progress in terms of adding power generation capacity, including renewable resources, and distributing, the official noted.

The next phase of growth for India’s power sector will depend on the software side,

regulatory frameworks, market design, pricing mechanisms, and institutional innovation.

Programmes such as PM-Kusum are already transforming farmers from passive consumers into active producers of energy. However, integrating large shares of in-energy requires new approaches, he said, adding that time of day tariff, demand response, flexible generation, and storage solutions will all play critical roles.

The secretary said India’s power sector has undergone a remarkable transformation that offers valuable lessons for stakeholders across the world.

Peak demand deficit has fallen sharply from about 4 per cent to nearly negligible levels. Installed capacity has more than doubled to exceed 520 GW. Renewable energy has been at the heart of this growth, particularly since 2016, with

tariffs falling significantly.

“This progress has not been accidental. It has been driven by deliberate policy design, standardised bidding frameworks, renewable purchase obligations, and visions that have enabled scale while reducing costs. Today, India is not only meeting its domestically enabled energy leads, but also emerging as a manufacturing and export hub,” Aggarwal said.

This raises an important question for all stakeholders here. “Are we ready to treat electricity, not as a static commodity but as a dynamic one, where value varies by time location and demand,” he said.

Earlier, speaking at the event, Union Power Minister Manohar Lal said India is planning to implement an under-sea power transmission cable network with the UAE as a part of One Sun, One World, One Grid Network.

He further said this is the inaugural Bharat Electricity Summit and will be held every two years from now on.

Union Minister for New and Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi said, “Our electronic goods, electronic production has increased from Rs 1.1 lakh crore to Rs 11.8 lakh crore, this is more than six times growth.”

Minister of State for Power, New and Renewable Energy Shripad Naik said 32 lakh households have been solarised under the PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana, of the targeted of 1 crore homes.

“Our renewable energy journey has been remarkable. From just 2.8 GW of solar capacity in 2014 to over 143 GW today, placing India among the global leadership in clean energy. We are now moving beyond the capacity creation towards a system,” he said.

LIC Foundation donates school bus in Tinsukia

TINSUKIA: The Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) Golden Jubilee Foundation donated a 43-seater school bus to Pranabanda Vidyamandir, run by Bharat Sevashram Sangha, to support education and community welfare.

The handover ceremony was attended by Saumitra Kumar De, Regional Manager (Corporate Communication), Eastern Zone, who reiterated LIC’s commitment to social upliftment and inclusive growth.

Highlighting the insurer’s financial performance for the nine months ended December 31, 2025, De said profit after tax rose 16.68 per cent to Rs 33,998 crore. Total premium income increased 9.02 per cent to Rs



3.71 lakh crore, while assets under management grew to about Rs 59.16 lakh crore.

LIC continues to lead the market with a 57.07 per cent share in first-year premium income. Under the Bima Sakhi Yojana, it has appointed over 2.97 lakh agents, strengthening rural outreach and women’s em-powerment. Senior officials, including Manoj Nathaniel, Nabarun Ghosh, Tarun Barua and Rahul Ghosh, were also present at the event.

RCF Kapurthala inaugurates All India Rly Women’s Hockey C’ship

KAPURTHALA: The 46th All India Railway Women’s Hockey Championship began on Thursday at Rail Coach Factory (RCF), Kapurthala, and will run till March 25, 2026.

Nine teams from Zonal Railways and Production Units are competing, divided into two pools for league matches. Pool A includes Central Railway Mumbai, South Eastern Railway Kolkata, Western Railway Mumbai, North Eastern Railway Gorakhpur and East Central Railway Hajipur. Pool B comprises RCF Kapurthala, North Central Railway Prayagraj, Northern Railway New Delhi and West Central Railway Jabalpur.

Top railway officials, sports



enthusiasts and spectators attended the opening ceremony, with several Olympians and international players participating.

On the opening day, Central Railway Mumbai beat Western Railway 5-2, while South

Eastern Railway Kolkata edged North Eastern Railway 3-2. Northern Railway New Delhi defeated North Central Railway 3-0. Host RCF Kapurthala dominated West Central Railway Jabalpur 14-0, with Annu named Player of the Match. MPOST

Bihar showcases investment potential at Bharat Electricity Summit

Transmission capacity has jumped nearly 20-fold, while the distribution network has grown more than five times

NEW DELHI: Bihar showcased its growing strength as an investment destination in the power sector while participating as the ‘Focus State’ at the Bharat Electricity Summit 2026 held at Yashobhoomi in the national capital.

The state presented its policy framework, infrastructure growth and future plans, drawing strong interest from investors, industry leaders and global delegates. The Bihar pavilion emerged as a key attraction during the summit, where officials held extensive discussions with stakeholders on potential collaborations and upcoming proj-



Brijendra Prasad Yadav, Minister of Energy, Govt of Bihar & Manoj Kumar Singh, IAS, Secretary, Dept. of Energy (Govt. of Bihar) and Chairman & MD, Bihar State Power Holding Corporation Ltd

ects. International participation further boosted the state’s profile, with representatives from

multiple countries and institutions expressing interest in Bihar’s evolving energy ecosys-

CLOSER LOOK

- » The state’s power availability has risen from less than 700 MW in 2005 to demand exceeding 8,700 MW
- » The state now provides near round-the-clock power across urban and rural areas, to over 2.2 crore consumers

power sector over the past two decades.

The state’s power availability has risen from less than 700 MW in 2005 to meeting demand exceeding 8,700 MW. It now provides near round-the-clock electricity across urban and rural areas, covering over 2.2 crore consumers.

Infrastructure expansion has played a crucial role in this transformation. Transmission capacity has increased nearly twenty-fold, while the distribution network has grown more than five times.

The number of grid substations has risen from 45 to 175,

along with a substantial increase in transformers, strengthening the state’s capacity to support industrial growth.

Operational efficiency has also improved, with distribution companies reporting a profit of over Rs 2,000 crore in FY25. AT&C losses have declined below the national average, and both DISCOMs have secured ‘A’ ratings.

Digital initiatives have further enhanced efficiency, with over 8.7 million smart prepaid meters installed, alongside advanced ERP systems, integrated dashboards and centralized command centres. MPOST

Key Points

- » About power transmission infra in the country, he states that by 2034, India will complete a 900 GW transmission line
- » ‘As far as energy transmission, is concerned, India has added 2.09 lakh circuit km of lines to the network in last 10 years’
- » ‘Our network is emerging as one of the strongest in the world, which will benefit us in the future’

Centre clears ₹497 crore ‘RELIEF’ scheme amid West Asia disruptions

Scheme includes extension of export obligations, logistical support and measures to manage shipping delays, higher freight & insurance costs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government on Thursday rolled out the RELIEF (Resilience & Logistics Intervention for Export Facilitation) scheme with an outlay of Rs 497 crore to provide relief to exporters facing disruptions due to the ongoing West Asia conflict.

The scheme, with the Export Credit Guarantee Corporation of India (ECGC) as the implementing agency, includes automatic extension of export obligations, logistical support, and potential financial measures to manage shipping delays and higher freight and insurance costs, according to a Commerce Ministry release.

The intervention is aimed at supporting Indian exporters affected by extraordinary freight escalation, heightened insurance premiums, and war-related export risks arising from disruptions in the Gulf and wider West Asia maritime corridor.

Speaking with reporters, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal said, “We are announcing a new scheme under the Export Promotion mission, especially focused upon exporters exposed to these 17-18 geographies which have been impacted by the conflict to



‘There has been some impact on the trade environment and exporters are facing certain challenges’

assuage some of the challenges that our exporters are facing.”

He said due to the West Asia conflict, there has been some impact on the trade environment and exporters are facing certain challenges, with a “sense of worry” particularly among those having exposure to countries in the Gulf region.

“There have been instances where the exports which were meant for some of the countries in the Middle East have not been able to reach their destinations. The future exports are also getting impacted. There is a sense of worry in exporters especially among those who

Highlights

» ‘There have been instances where exports which were meant for some of the countries in the Middle East have not been able to reach their destinations’

» Director General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) Lav Agarwal told reporters that there was dual shock as both air and maritime cargo were affected

have exposure to the Middle East markets,” Agrawal said.

He also informed that an inter-ministerial group (IMG) has been set up comprising various government departments, including the Commerce ministry, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, Ports and Shipping, Department of Financial Services, Ministry of External Affairs, and officials from the RBI, CBIC, etc, which meets daily to assess the evolving situation based on cargo movement.

Director General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) Lav Agarwal told reporters that there was dual shock as both air and mari-

time cargo were affected.

“There were challenges related with the sharp increase in logistics costs, war-risk premiums and emergency surcharges. Similarly, there were challenges due to cargo accumulation at ports and airports with perishable and refrigerated cargo most affected,” he said.

The Commerce & Industry Ministry said recent developments, including heightened security concerns around the Strait of Hormuz, have led to vessel diversions, longer sailing routes, congestion at transhipment hubs and emergency conflict-linked surcharges. These developments have increased logistics costs and created operational uncertainty for export consignments moving to or through the region.

“In view of the evolving geopolitical situation in West Asia and its impact on maritime logistics across the Gulf region, the Government has approved a time-bound and targeted intervention called RELIEF - Resilience & Logistics Intervention for Export Facilitation under the Export Promotion Mission (EPM). The intervention is aimed at supporting Indian exporters affected by extraordinary freight escalation, heightened insur-

ance premia and war-related export risks arising from disruptions in the Gulf and wider West Asia maritime corridor,” the ministry said.

The RELIEF scheme mainly covers consignments destined for delivery or transhipment to the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Qatar, Oman, Bahrain, Iraq, Iran, Israel, and Yemen.

The scheme has three key components. Component I includes Export Obligation Extensions: Automatic extension for Advance Authorisations and EPCG authorisations (due between March 1 and May 31, 2026) until August 31, 2026, without penalty. It protects already insured shipments by ECGC in the immediate one-month window from February 14-March 15.

Component II is aimed at encouraging and facilitating ECGC coverage for upcoming exports consignments over three months from March 16 to June 15.

The Component III specifically targets MSMEs to shield them from surcharge shocks and partly reimburses extraordinary freight and insurance costs over one month from February 14 to March 15. It is applicable for MSME exporters who have not taken ECGC coverage.

TO OPERATE AT 80% CAPACITY NOW Urea plants get additional natural gas in spot auction

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Fertiliser companies have purchased additional natural gas from the spot market to ramp up urea production at their plants, which are operating well below capacity due to a fuel shortage amid the West Asia crisis, a senior government official said on Thursday.

After the procurement of additional natural gas, urea plants are expected to operate at 78-80 per cent capacity compared to 62 per cent currently.

India produced 306.67 lakh tonnes of urea in 2024-25 and imported 56.47 lakh tonnes of the nutrient to meet the domestic demand.

The country has imported 98 lakh tonnes of urea in the first eleven months of this fiscal.

Fertiliser plants in the country require about 52 million metric standard cubic metres per day (MMSCMD) of natural gas to operate at full capacity, but were receiving only around 32 MMSCMD, meeting barely 62 per cent of their requirement, resulting in a significant shortfall in urea output, the official said.

To address this, a spot auction was conducted by the government, where fertiliser plants collectively sought 8.56 MMSCMD of additional gas and secured 7.31 MMSCMD, with supplies to be delivered

India produced 306.67 lakh tonnes of urea in 2024-25 & imported 56.47 lakh tonnes of the nutrient to meet the domestic demand

immediately from March 19 to March 31, the official said.

With this additional procurement, the total gas availability at fertiliser plants has risen to approximately 40 MMSCMD, a jump of around 23 per cent over the earlier supply level.

Plants are now expected to operate at 78 to 80 per cent of installed capacity, compared to 62 per cent earlier, the official added.

The additional gas is expected to result in incremental urea production of 12,500-13,000 tonnes per day until the end of this month, the official said.

The government official described the move as a significant step by the government to bridge the demand-supply gap and ensure adequate availability of the key farm input ahead of the upcoming kharif season.

As of March 19, 2026, India has a stock of 61.14 lakh tonnes of urea against 55.22 lakh tonnes a year ago. The

stock of DAP (di-ammonium phosphate) is 24.24 lakh tonnes compared to 11.85 lakh tonnes, while the stock of NPKs is 57.21 lakh tonnes against 34.44 lakh tonnes.

The Centre provides urea to farmers at a subsidised rate of 242 per bag (45 kg) (exclusive of charges towards neem coating and taxes applicable).

The difference between the cost of production and the maximum retail price is paid to the manufacturers as a subsidy.

The US and Israel have launched military strikes on targets in Iran at the end of February. Tehran retaliated with missiles and drones aimed at Israel and countries hosting US forces, including the United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Kuwait, Bahrain, Iraq, Jordan and Saudi Arabia.

Many urea plants have advanced their maintenance shutdown in view of the shortage of natural gas.

“The current lean period is traditionally when fertiliser companies schedule plant shutdowns for repair and maintenance. These companies have now come forward to prepone their maintenance scheduled to March to utilise the disruptive time to their advantage,” the Department of Fertiliser said on March 6.

Multiple global sources are also being tapped for additional imports of finished fertilisers, it added.

APSEZ in Colombo hits 1 mn TEUs in first year

COLOMBO: Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) operating at the Colombo port's west terminal has achieved the milestone of handling one million TEUs in its first year of operations.

“A rapid first-year ramp-up at the Port of Colombo in Sri Lanka underscores the expanding global footprint of APSEZ, highlighting both the growing importance of the Indian Ocean Region in global trade flows and its emerging role in the blue economy,” a statement said.

The Colombo West International Terminal is a partnership between APSEZ, John Keells Holdings PLC, one of Sri Lanka's most respected conglomerates, and the Sri Lanka Ports Authority.

The group's \$800 million investment came in the backdrop of Colombo strengthening its role as a key transshipment hub, linking cargo flows across Asia, West Asia and Europe.

The west terminal is the first fully automated deep-water terminal at the Port of Colombo, built to handle the latest generation of ultra-large container vessels. Its 1,400-metre quay and water depth of around 20 metres allow it to berth some of the largest ships operating on the Asia-Europe trade route.

With an annual capacity of about 3.2 million TEUs (Twenty-foot Equivalent Unit), the terminal significantly expands Colombo's handling capability.

Govt sold 200 mineral blocks in FY26 Out of the 200 auctioned blocks, 123 are mining lease blocks and 77 are composite licence blocks

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Thursday said it has sold a record 200 mineral blocks in 2025-26, the highest ever in a single year, with Tamil Nadu conducting auctions for the first time and Uttarakhand entering the fray by selling its maiden magnesite block.

Out of the 200 auctioned blocks, 123 are mining lease blocks and 77 are composite licence blocks, indicating a balanced mix of operational and exploration-focused opportunities.

Additionally, notices inviting tenders (NITs) for 70 mineral blocks — 38 mining leases (ML) and 32 composite licences (CL) — are currently underway which is likely to further boost the total number



of successful auctions in the financial year.

Gujarat led with 32 blocks, followed by Rajasthan with 30 blocks, and Tamil Nadu with 22 blocks, emerging as the top contributors, the Mines Ministry said in a statement.

Their efforts in timely block preparation, data management, and procedural efficiency have strengthened the national auction ecosystem.

Notably, Tamil Nadu has successfully conducted mineral block auctions for the first time, marking an important milestone.

Uttarakhand has also entered the mineral auction framework with the successful auction of its first magnesite block, the mines ministry said.

The ministry further said that in this year, 22 critical mineral blocks were auctioned, reflecting the increasing focus on minerals of strategic importance for long-term resource security.

Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Karnataka, and Maharashtra played a major role in offering these blocks, contributing five, four, four, three and two blocks respectively.

Market correction tremendous opportunity for FPIs to invest in India: Sebi whole time member

MUMBAI: Equity market corrections following the Middle East conflict present a “tremendous opportunity” for foreign portfolio investors to up their bets in India, a senior Sebi official said on Thursday.

Kamlesh Chandra Varshney, a whole-time member (WTM) at the capital markets regulator, said the Indian capital market is “quite attractive” now and presents a good opportunity to investors registered as FPIs.

“There is a tremendous opportunity to invest in the Indian equity market with the kind of direction which has taken place now in the last few months, particularly after the war that has broken out,” he



said, speaking at a Russia-India forum for integration of capital markets here.

FPIs continue to be net sellers in the Indian markets in FY26, and in the first 12 days of March alone, there has been a sell-off of over Rs 77,000 crore by them, as per reports.

Speaking at the event, Varshney assured all help to

facilitate Russian investments into the country and also proposed setting up working groups to take care of any specific requirements on the same.

He urged Russian companies to also opt for initial public offerings (IPOs) in India, pointing out that some foreign companies' local arms enjoy a higher valuation in India than the parent in the home market.

Varshney said 23 Russian entities have registered with Sebi as FPIs, and can access both the debt and equities markets locally.

Speaking at the same event, Sergey Glazeyev, the state secretary of the Union state of Russia and Belarus, pitched for a new international payment system

which will be driven by a new digital currency.

“We should create a new financial architecture which is based on national currency and international transparency and trust to each other,” he said.

The US will not be successful in the war that it has begun in Iran with Israel, and the focus of the world economy will shift to South and East Asia, Glazeyev added.

Largest equity bourse NSE's chief executive and managing director Ashishkumar Chauhan said the Russia-India partnership is one of depth, continuity and strategic relevance, and the task is to translate that into practical financial architecture.



Reserve Bank said there were no material concerns on record as regards the bank's conduct or governance.

“HDFC Bank is a Domestic Systemically Important Bank (D-SIB) with sound financials, a professionally run board and a competent management team. Based on our periodic assessment, there are no material concerns on record as regards its conduct or governance,” the Reserve Bank said in a statement.

Silver crashes ₹17,800/kg, gold dives to ₹1.53 lakh/10 gms on global selloff

NEW DELHI: Silver prices tanked Rs 17,800 to Rs 2.38 lakh per kilogram in the national capital on Thursday, while gold dropped Rs 7,000 to Rs 1.53 lakh per 10 grams following a sharp selloff in global commodity markets.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, the white metal slumped by Rs 17,800, or nearly 7 per cent, to Rs 2,38,700 per kg from Wednesday's closing level of Rs 2,56,500 per kg. Silver has now declined sharply by Rs 1,65,800 per kilogram, or 41 per cent, from its lifetime high of Rs 4,04,500 per kg recorded on January 29.

Gold of 99.9 per cent purity also plunged by Rs 7,000, or 4.37 per cent, to Rs 1,53,300 per 10



grams from the previous close of Rs 1,60,300 per 10 grams.

The yellow metal had fallen by Rs 29,700, or 16.23 per cent, from its all-time high of Rs 1,83,000 per 10 grams recorded on January 29.

Analysts attributed the steep fall in bullion prices to a combination of factors, including rising inflation concerns, hawkish central bank stances, particularly from the US Fed-

eral Reserve and the Bank of Japan, amid surging global crude prices.

Gold and silver prices resumed their downward trajectory on Thursday amid rising global inflation concerns, Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemnon Markets Desk, said. He added that geopolitical tensions stemming from the ongoing conflict between the US and Iran, leading to fears of oil supply disruptions that could further fuel inflation.

Precious metal prices also traded lower in the overseas trade. Spot silver tumbled by \$4.88, or 6.48 per cent, to \$70.49 per ounce, and gold declined \$140.19, or nearly 3 per cent, to \$4,678.69 per ounce.

Misuse of Insolvency & Bankruptcy Code by defaulters can badly impact economy: HC

‘Such strategies by loan defaulters frustrate the very objective of the IBC and paralyse the whole process of lawful steps taken by secured creditors’

MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court has deprecated the misuse of provisions of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) by loan defaulters and guarantors to “wear a cloak of immunity” by triggering a moratorium, and said this practice has the tendency to adversely impact the country's economy.

A bench of Justices Manish Pitale and Shreeram Shirsat, in an order passed on Wednesday, said such strategies by loan defaulters frustrate the very objective of the IBC and paralyse the whole process of lawful steps taken by secured

creditors, adding that the court cannot remain a mute spectator when misuse of legal provisions demonstrates failure of justice.

The court said it has noticed a “disturbing trend” in which chronic defaulters take resort to the provisions of the IBC to frustrate secured creditors and auction purchasers from proceeding under the provisions of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act.

In a number of such matters, it is found that the borrowers/guarantors act as fence

sitters and do not take any steps when secured creditors proceed under the Securitisation Act and till the culmination of the process and auction purchasers come into the picture, the HC said.

At this stage, the borrowers/guarantors initiate collusive proceedings under the IBC, claiming triggering of moratorium before the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), it said.

“As a consequence, all steps taken under the Securitisation Act suddenly come to a standstill and such borrowers/guarantors, who are default-

CLOSER LOOK

- » The court has noticed a ‘disturbing trend in which chronic defaulters take resort to the IBC provisions to frustrate secured creditors & auction purchasers from proceeding
- » In a number of such matters, it is found that borrowers/guarantors act as fence sitters & do not take any steps when secured creditors proceed under Securitisation Act
- » The court cannot remain a ‘mute spectator’ when misuse of legal provisions demonstrates failure of justice, it said

ers, wear a cloak of immunity under the garb of moratorium triggered under the IBC,” the court said.

In its judgment, the HC

noted that the objective of the IBC was to ensure that insolvency resolution of corporate persons and individuals are undertaken in a time-bound

manner for maximisation of value of assets, availability of credit and balance the interest of all stakeholders.

“We found that the manner in which the defaulting borrowers and guarantors have been taking recourse to the provisions of the IBC, shows that such strategies are frustrating the very objective of the IBC, apart from paralyzing the whole process of lawful steps taken by secured creditors under the Securitisation Act,” the HC said.

Chronic defaulters of loan and financial facilities, when facing the heat of proceedings

initiated by secured creditors, scamper to file proceedings under the IBC in a collusive manner so as to claim that moratorium is triggered, the HC said.

It added that in such a situation, the creditor or the auction purchaser has to approach the NCLT followed by the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) and then the Supreme Court, till which time they are completely frustrated.

The bench said such a practice has the tendency of adversely affecting the economy, financial health and

business environment in the country.

In such situations, the court cannot remain a “mute spectator” when misuse of legal provisions demonstrates failure of justice, it said.

The remarks were made in a petition filed by Rozina Firoz Hajiani and others, who were successful auction bidders for a south Mumbai property, challenging an order passed by the Debts Recovery Tribunal (DRT) putting their sale registration on hold as the borrowers had initiated proceedings under the IBC before the NCLT.

'MY ROLE WILL BE SIMILAR TO LAST YEAR'

Unfazed by pressure, Ashutosh wants to finish in style for DC

NEW DELHI: Ashutosh Sharma doesn't feel the pressure of performing on a grand stage like the IPL and remains focussed on finishing more games for Delhi Capitals in 2026 than the last season.

In his first season for DC, Impact Player Ashutosh began the tournament with a bang, smashing 31-ball 66 not out to pull off a thrilling win over LSG.

However, he and his team and were not able to ride the initial momentum created in the tournament, failing to make the play-offs.

Speaking to PTI, Ashutosh spoke about his preparation for his third season in the IPL beginning on March 28.

"The preparation is going very well. We have attended 3-4 pre-season camps. My role would be similar to last year, finishing games for the team at number 6 or 7. I want to win as many games as possible," said Ashutosh, who rose to prominence with his exploits for Punjab Kings in 2024.



"I don't feel the pressure when I am in the middle. I believe in my ability and my hardwork"

Ashutosh Sharma,

The 27-year-old from Madhya Pradesh who plays domestic cricket for Railways surprisingly doesn't feel the pressure when he is playing in front of a packed crowd, a usual scene in the IPL.

The finisher's role is all about keeping calm in high-pressure situations and Ashutosh seems to have figured out that part of his game.

"I don't feel the pressure when I am in the middle. I believe in my ability and my hardwork. This season I have not developed a new shot or something. It is just about perfecting the game I already have," he said.

With the inclusion Lungi Ngidi and David Miller in the side, Ashutosh feels the unit is well balanced. The Axar Patel-led unit finished fifth in the previous edition.

Is there someone with whom he discusses the game regularly? "I have a few friends. I talk to Shikhar bhai (Dhawan) sometimes about the game and life in general," he said. AGENCIES

A king for the Royals

Like Rohit and Virat, Sanju can't be replaced: RR skipper Riyan Parag



Rajasthan Royals' captain Riyan Parag and others warm up during a practice session on Wednesday

PTI

JAIPUR: Rajasthan Royals skipper Riyan Parag on Thursday said the void left by Sanju Samson's departure to Chennai Super Kings cannot be filled as finding a replacement for the T20 World Cup hero is as impossible as replacing stalwarts like Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli in the Indian team.

Sanju, who led the Royals from 2021 to 2025, was traded to Chennai Super Kings in a pre-season move, with Ravindra Jadeja coming in as part of the deal.

"If you talk about Sanju bhaiya, we never think about replacing the kind of player he is," Parag told reporters in a pre-season press conference here. "We can perhaps look for someone with a similar skill-set or have someone bat in his position...It's like there is no replacement for Virat Kohli or Rohit Sharma... In the same way, there is no replacement for Sanju bhaiya because he is such a good player," Parag said, referring to the two superstars who only play the ODI format now.

Having represented the franchise for 11 years across two stints, Sanju was RR's most successful captain and leading run-scorer, having guided them to the IPL 2022 final and the playoffs in 2024.

His stature has grown manifold following a stellar T20 World Cup campaign, where he struck three successive match-defining knocks to power India to a historic title defence. He was adjudged player of the tournament for the phenomenal performance.

Rajasthan Royals had a forgettable last season, enduring 10 defeats to finish ninth in the 10-team standings.

Parag, who has been picked as the captain following Sanju's exit, said RR lost far too many

close matches last year and the 2008 winners need better strategy and planning.

"This year, the focus is to plan better and finish games, which we couldn't do in the previous edition," he said.

"We need to plan well. Last year, there were about 5-6 games which we lost in the last over or even on the last ball. Had we been able to convert those, or had we calculated better, this question (if RR would try anything new) would not have been asked because we

would have qualified (for knockouts) by winning those matches," he explained.

The Royals' director of cricket and head coach Kumar Sangakkara said he has always "admired" Parag as a cricketer and he was picked as a skipper after a robust round of interviews with other candidates.

"It was about trying to find the best person who can lead the Rajasthan Royals. I (first) met Riyan when he was a teenager and have admired him as a cricketer," he said. AGENCIES

Let Vaibhav be, says Parag

JAIPUR: Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag on Thursday said Indian batting prodigy Vaibhav Sooryavanshi should be allowed to enjoy his game without taking any additional pressure in and out of the field.

Parag indicated that Sooryavanshi will pair up with India opener Yashasvi Jaiswal in the IPL beginning March 28 and said the 14-year-old should be given his space and time to continue developing in his game without any outside pressure.

"As a captain my message to him would be to not do a lot of press conferences or follow a lot of media," Parag said during a pre-season press conference. "Let him just enjoy, which I will request you (media) as well. Do not reach out to his manager or anyone; just let him be. He's a 15-16 (14) year-old kid, let him play cricket." AGENCIES

Maharashtra Jeevan Pradhikaran Division Mangaon.
e-Tender Notice No. 7 for 2025-2026

Executive Engineer, Maharashtra Jeevan Pradhikaran, Division Mangaon invites e-Tender for the work of **Umate Rural Regional Water Supply Scheme Tq. Alibag Dist. Under JJM Retrofitting of Existing 4.5 MLD WTP RS.29,03,440/-**

The e-Tender details are available on www.mahatenders.gov.in from Dated 20/03/2026.

Date:- 16/03/2026
Dgipr/2025-26/6675

Prashant Pandharpatte (Act.)
Executive Engineer MJP
Division Mangaon



कार्यपालक अभियन्ता का कार्यालय
पूर्वी कोशी तटबंध प्रमण्डल, चंद्रायण
अल्पकालीन निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना
संख्या-04 F2 / 2025-2026
(केवल ई-टेंडर पद्धति के अनुसार वेबसाइट www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in पर)
कार्य का विवरण :-

श्रुप सं	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि (लाख रु० में)	अग्रगण्य की राशि (लाख रु० में) (ऑनलाइन आवेदक निशाना / मुद्रा (लाख रु० में)	परिमाण-विशेष का मूल्य (आवृत्त/मी०) (केवल ऑनलाइन मोड में मुद्रा) (रु० में)	बैलेंस का देय "बीड प्रोसेसिंग फी" (आवृत्त/मी०) (केवल ऑनलाइन मोड में मुद्रा) (रु० में)	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि	अनुमति
1	1. बिहार सरकार के अग्रगण्य प्रबंध नीहडा नाम वेबसाइट कार्यालय-02 में बांध वर्ष 2026 पूर्व ग्राम सुधारका कार्य। (Agenda No- 246/38/2026)	36.08	0.73000	5000.00	590.00	15.05.2026	
2.	2. बिहार सरकार के अग्रगण्य प्रबंध नीहडा नाम वेबसाइट कार्यालय-02 में बांध वर्ष 2026 पूर्व ग्राम सुधारका कार्य। (Agenda No- 246/41/2026)	29.82	0.60000	5000.00	590.00	15.05.2026	
3	3. बिहार सरकार के अग्रगण्य प्रबंध नीहडा के नाम एरजी कडुआर में बांध वर्ष 2026 पूर्व ग्राम सुधारका कार्य। (Agenda No- 246/40/2026)	70.43	1.41000	10000.00	3540	15.05.2026	
4	4. बिहार सरकार के अग्रगण्य प्रबंध नीहडा के नाम वेबसाइट कार्यालय-02 में बांध वर्ष 2026 पूर्व ग्राम सुधारका कार्य। (Agenda No- 246/44/2026)	79.93	1.60000	10000.00	3540	15.05.2026	

2. निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना निर्मात की तिथि : 17.03.2026

3. निविदा कागजात खानलोल करने एवं निविदा : दिनांक-25.03.2026 के 10:30 बजे पूर्वहन से दिनांक-02.04.2026 अपलोल करने की तिथि एवं समय (सिर्फ वेबसाइट eproc2.bihar.gov.in पर)

4. प्री बिड मीटिंग का समय, स्थान एवं तिथि : दिनांक-02.04.2026 के 02:00 बजे अपराहन से 5:00बजे अपराहन तक मुख्य अभियंता बाड निरंयण एवं जल निस्सरण जलसंसाधन विभाग वीरपुर के कार्यालय में

5. तकनीकी बिड खोलने की तिथि एवं समय : दिनांक-04.04.2026 समय 3:30 P.M (सिर्फ वेबसाइट www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in पर)

6. वित्तीय बिड खोलने की तिथि एवं समय : सख्म पदाधिकारी द्वारा बांध में घोषित की जायेगी। (सिर्फ वेबसाइट www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in पर)

7. निविदा खोलने का स्थान- : www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in पर।

8. निविदा की वैधता की अवधि :- 120 दिन

9. विज्ञापनदाता का पदनाम एवं पता :- कार्यपालक अभियन्ता, पूर्वी कोशी तटबंध प्रमंडल चंद्रायण

निविदा की वित्तृत जानकारी state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar से प्राप्त की जा सकती है।

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता,
पूर्वी कोशी तटबंध प्रमंडल चंद्रायण
मो0न0-7463889483

PR- 026695 (WRD) 2025-26

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।

Jaipur Optiemus Achievers Beat Jindal Panther

NEW DELHI: The Jaipur Optiemus Achievers defeated Jindal Panther 9-6 in an exhibition match at the Jaipur Polo Grounds on a breezy, rain-soaked evening in New Delhi on March 19, 2026. Despite intermittent showers, nearly 1,000 spectators attended the contest, creating a lively atmosphere that included prominent guests and students from Maharaja Agrasen Medical College.

Speaking after the match, Naveen Jindal said, "It's always special to be here at the iconic Jaipur Polo Grounds, one of the most historic venues for the sport in India. This ground is not just a venue, it is the heart of Indian polo and home to the Indian Polo Association." MPOST



NEW DELHI: Indian men's hockey coach Craig Fulton has promised a "tailored and detailed" plan for each one of the tricky opponents that await his team in the World Cup later this year and backed the currently faltering side to peak at the right time.

India have managed just one win this season, a penalty shootout triumph over Australia in an FIH Pro League match in Hobart. The team is drawn to play top-seeded England, traditional rivals Pakistan, and a determined Wales side in Pool D of the



India have grouped alongside rivals Pakistan in the World Cup FILE

World Cup starting August 15 in the Netherlands and Belgium. All group-stage matches will be held at the Wagener Hockey Sta-

India to play T20Is in Ireland

NEW DELHI: World champions India will tour Ireland for a T20I series in June ahead of their white-ball assignment in England.

Ireland's director of high performance Graham West confirmed the series when he announced Paul Stirling's decision to step down as their T20I captain.

India, who host Afghanistan for a one-off Test and a three-match ODI series ending on June 20, will travel to England for five T20Is and three ODIs from July 1-19, while the Ireland series will precede the English

New-castled at Barca

UCL: Catalans score 7 as Reds down Galtasarar, Bayern cruise



Raphinha scores the opener against Newcastle

AFP

LONDON: Barcelona scored seven and Liverpool revived their season with four goals to flip tight Champions League games Wednesday into big wins sending them to the quarterfinals.

Atletico Madrid survived a pulsating Tottenham fightback to make it Spain 3, England 0 in Round-of-16 clashes this week.

Bayern Munich had it easiest of all, pushing aside Atalanta 4-1 on Wednesday and 10-2

7-2

Barcelona's 7-2 win is the biggest margin of victory for a Spanish side against an English opponent since May 1966

on aggregate, to get a blockbuster quarterfinal against Real Madrid.

Another Champions League goals rush was sparked by Barcelona tearing apart Newcastle in the second half of a thrilling 7-2 win after the teams went toe-to-toe before the break. Tied 1-1 after the first leg in Newcastle, Barcelona surged to a victory after Lamine Yamal's momentum-shifting penalty kick in first-half stoppage time made the score 3-2.

Robert Lewandowski then scored twice, Fermin Lopez finished a slick move and Raphinha got his second goal as Newcastle's defense collapsed.

Liverpool ultimately eased to a 4-0 win over Galatasaray at Anfield, overturning a one-goal loss in Istanbul, despite Mohamed Salah missing a penalty in first-half stoppage time when the score was 1-0. AGENCIES

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE


Branch office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice. Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Mohammad Usman-Deceased (Through His Legal Heir) / Mohd Nawazish/ Zubeda/ LBDEL00004973902	Dda Lig Flat Bearing No.69, Ground Floor, Jahangir Puri Delhi- 110033 / March 17, 2026	October 31, 2025 Rs. 2,32,514.88/-	Delhi Ncr
2.	Arfia Khan / Anil Siwatch/ Waseem Ahmad Khan / LBNOD00004308253	Flat No. 10 GF 2, Ground Floor Building No. 10, Pristine Situated At Plot No. SC- 1/A-1 Sector 150, Gautam Budha Nagar, U.P. Noida- 201301 / March 17, 2026	March 27, 2025 Rs. 1,96,98,832/-	Delhi Ncr/ Uttarakhand Kiccha Sonipat Gohana
3.	Arfia Wasim Khan/ Taj Stone Crushes LLP/ Waseem Ahamad Khan/ LBDEL00003217868	House No. 7 Block E, Sector Beta 01 Gautam Budha Nagar Greater Noida- 201308 / March 17, 2026	March 27, 2025 Rs. 84,34,654.19/-	Delhi Ncr/ Uttarakhand Kiccha/ Bareilly
4.	Mukesh Kumar / Anju Singh/ KPS Clinical Services Private Limited/ LBDEL00001916302	Flat No. 208, Tower K, 2nd Floor Avj Heights Situated At Plot No. Gh-12/2 Situated In Sector Zeta I, Gautam Budh Nagar Greater Noida 201307, Owned By Mukesh Kumar & Anju Singh / March 17, 2026	November 19, 2025 Rs. 6,37,171/-	Delhi Ncr
5.	Manoj Chaturvedi / Gayatri Chaturvedi / LBNOD00002069299	Flat No. T26/22 01 22nd Floor, Tower 26 Paras Tierrea Sector 137 Noida- 201301 / March 17, 2026	November 10, 2025 Rs. 44,89,226.59/-	Delhi Ncr

The above-mentioned borrower(s)/guarantor(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, as the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: March 20, 2026 Place: Delhi/Ncr
Sincerely Authorised Officer For ICICI Bank Ltd.

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
P.W.D. (B&R) AMBIKPUR CIRCLE AMBIKAPUR

Invitation Date :- 17.03.2026

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

01. For tender detail please visit <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>
02. Concern Division - Pathalgaon Division
03. S.No. 1 'C' Class And Above Contractor
04. Bid Submission Due Date - 02.04.2026

S. No.	N.I.T.No.	Name of work	P.A.C. in lacs
1	2	3	4
1	238	Construction of Pakhnpara Maado Gufa Approach Road Length 1.50 Km. in Gram Panchayat Karabewra Distt Jashpur (C.G.) (Second Call)	186.36

Superintending Engineer
P.W.D. Ambikapur Circle Ambikapur

G 252607283/5

EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD BRIDGE CONSTRUCTION DIVISION BHOPAL
Tender Notice

NIT No- 05/Setu/2026/E.E.(Bridge Division.)
Online Tender for mentioned below are being invited. The Tender have been uploaded on the mptenders. system of Public Works Department on the Portal www.ruptenders.gov.in Tender details are as below:-
Date 10-03-2026

S.N o.	Tender No.	District	Nature of work	Name of work	Call No.	Cost of Project (PAC) (Rs. In lacs)	Remarks
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1	2026_PWDR_B_488827_1	Narmdapuram	Bridge Work	Construction Of High Level Bridge Across River in K.M. 6/2 of Semri - Sangakheda Road Distt. Narmdapuram	Second	444.14	Original FDR payment will be online and all documents will be submitted online.
2	2026_PWDR_B_488839_1	Narmdapuram	Bridge Work	Construction of Submersible Bridge Across Bakud River in km 13/2 on Bahal- Nasirabad Dhana road Distt Narmdapuram	Second	445.01	Original FDR payment will be online and all documents will be submitted online.
3	2026_PWDR_B_489003_1	Sehore	Bridge Work	Construction of Submersible Bridge In Ladkui Tehsil Bherunda Distt Sehore in Tikamod and Suned River.	Second	491.30	Original FDR payment will be online and all documents will be submitted online.
				Total		1380.45	

The document can only be purchased online from the above website after making online payment. The last date & time for purchase of Document online is Dated 30-03-2026 up to (17:30). Detailed NIT and other details can be viewed on the above mentioned portal. Amendments to NIT, if any, would be published on website only, and not in newspaper. The Original FDR payment will be online and all documents will be submitted online. Physically, any type of documents will not be submitted in the office.

SD/- Executive Engineer
PWD Bridge Construction Division Bhopal

G27669/25

"स्वामि स्वकृता, संस्कार स्वकृता"

U-20 WOMEN'S ASIAN CUP
India women banking on European training

NEW DELHI: India captain Shubhangi Singh says a rigorous month-long training stint in Europe has sharpened the Indian U20 team for its return to the AFC U20 Women's Asian Cup. India will enter the continental stage event after two decades.

With just two weeks to go before their opening clash against Japan in Thailand, the Young Tigresses will look to translate that preparation into performance, led by captain Shubhangi when they walk out on April 2. "We prepared really well. Spending a month in Sweden and playing against European clubs was a great experience. Those teams were physically taller and stronger than us, so it helped us understand how to handle that," Shubhangi said.

For the skipper, the significance of qualification is already in the rearview. The celebrations in Myanmar, where India sealed their long-awaited return, have given way to a sharper, more immediate focus.

"We went there with the mindset to qualify, and we did. When you already believe something is going to happen, it doesn't come as a surprise," she said.

That belief now anchors a squad bracing for a stern test in Group C. India face Japan on April 2, Australia on April 5, and Chinese Taipei on April 8, with

India will enter the continental stage event after two decades

the top two teams and the two best third-placed sides advancing to the quarter-finals.

The four semi-finalists will qualify for the FIFA U20 Women's World Cup Poland 2026.

Currently training in Kolkata, the Young Tigresses will depart for Bangkok early Friday morning. "Our focus is on the three difficult group games ahead. At this stage, we don't expect any easy matches. We're ready to go out there and perform against top teams. We'll also have some preparatory matches before the Asian Cup, which will help," she said.

India's build-up has been extensive. Along with the Sweden camp, they have played multiple international friendlies against Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan, gaining exposure to high-intensity, physical football. A heavy 0-6 defeat to Hammarby IF's senior side in their opening game in Sweden proved a reality check, but also a turning point. "The first game was the toughest. The loss wasn't acceptable, but it was a big learning experience."

AGENCIES

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

E-Tender Notice

Sr. DEE/TRD/Agra for & on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on-line only (E-Tendering) for the following work:

Tender No. : AGCTRD702604	Approximate Cost : Rs. 21,33,800.90/-
Name of work : Provision of 50 KVAAT & change over panel for Dholpur station of Agra Division.	
Earnest Money : Rs. 42,700/-	Period of completion : Nine months

1. For full details & submission of the bid please see the Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in 2. Tender can only be submitted through web portal "www.ireps.gov.in" up to 15:30 Hrs. on date 13.04.2026 616/26 (C)

 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPNCR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC/84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kartik S/o Lt. Rama Swami R/o House No. 156, SIM Colony, Mori Gate, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 200/2022, U/S 25 Arms Act, PS Subzi Mandi, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Kartik** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Kartik** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Kartik of FIR No. 200/2022, U/S 25 Arms Act, PS Subzi Mandi, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **29.04.2026**

By Order,
Ms. Preeti Rajoria
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
Room No. 32
DP/2264/N/2026(Court Matter)
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER

E-Tender Notice No. CW-OT-TECH-MHK-26-27-1. For and on behalf of President of India, Dy Chief Mechanical Engineer (Carriage Works), Kharagpur Workshop, Kharagpur invites e-tender for the following works. **Name of Work :** Mechanized Housekeeping activities of shop floor, Shop offices, regular sorting, loading, unloading and handling of Non-metallic zero value scraps and Ferrous and Non-ferrous scraps from different location of Carriage shop, by outside agency. **Place of work :** Kharagpur Workshop, South Eastern Railway, Post-Kharagpur, Dist-Paschim Midnapore, Pin-721301. **Period :** 12 months. **Tender Value :** ₹ 1,23,31,850.64. **Earnest Money (Existing Value) :** ₹ 2,11,700/- **Cost of Tender Document :** Nil. **Contract Period :** 12 months from the date of issue of LOA. **Closing Date and time of Tender :** At 13.04.2026, 15.00 hrs. **Bidding System :** Two Packet System. **Contract Type :** Service-General. **Tender Type :** Open. Detail Tender Notice and Tender Document is available in the e-Portal website: <https://www.ireps.gov.in> (PR-1327)

**LOST & FOUND**

I, Rajiv Ranjan Dutta S/o Chandradev Dutta R/o F-1702, 17th Floor, Amrapali Platinum, Noida, Sector-119, Parthala Khanjarpur, PO: Parthala Khanjarpur, Dist-Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201304, do hereby declare that I have lost my original Builder Buyer Agreement (BBA) of my property Flat No-T5-1604, Crystal Homes Noida, Sector-76 somewhere in Noida sector-70. I have registered a police complaint to Gautam Buddha Nagar district police. Any misuse of BBA documents will be considered illegal! If anyone finds the above documents, please contact this number. 9650535500

**New Okhla Industrial Development Authority**

Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida, (U.P.)
Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from eligible firms/contractors for the following job against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these website for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

A) (Rs. 1.00 Lacs to 30.00 Lacs)

Sl. No	JOB NO	Sale Start Date	Sale End Date	Tender Opening Date and Time
1	Job No. - 06/E-Tender / SPO/2025-26 Name of Work - Procurement of summer uniform (Safari suit) fabric Estimated Cost Rs. 20,76,900.00	23.03.2026	06.04.2026 upto 5:00 P.M.	07.04.2026 11:00 A.M.

Office: Sector - 39
Store Purchase Officer NOIDA
CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr. PC/)
(84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Surender S/o Ram Dhalip R/o H.No. 3/423, 424, Khirchripur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CT No. 2315/2020, U/s 138 NI Act at PS: Mandawali, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Surender** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Surender** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Surender of CT No.2315/2020, U/s 138 NI Act of PS: Mandawali, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.04.2026**.

By order
Prerna Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
East District, Court No.15, First Floor,
Karkardooma Courts Delhi
DP/3359/ED/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Expression of Interest (EOI)

For and on behalf of the president of India, PCME/NR invites EOI to empanel competent and experienced agencies for providing enhanced On-Board Services as per the policy guidelines on "Reforms for Better On-Board Services" and Technical Evaluation Criteria, vide Railway Board (RB) Policy (Reform for Better on-board Services) No.2026/ENRHM/15/09-OBHS dated 17.02.2026.

- The interested firms are requested to submit their complete proposal on or before date 02.04.2026, 15:00 hrs. Opening time 02.04.2026 at 15:30 hrs.
- The EOI proposals should be submitted in the Box available in O/o Dy. CME/ Chg/HQNR, Room No. 140, First Floor, Mechanical Department, Northern Railway, Headquarters Office, Annex-4, Baroda House, New Delhi-110001, on any working day during office hours.
- For further details, please visit Northern Railway website or office of Chief Rolling Stock Engineer (CRSE/Chg./NR), Northern Railway Mechanical Department.

Website: <https://nr.indianrailways.gov.in>
e-mail: crsechgnr@gmail.com, dymechchgnr@gmail.com
No: NR-HQ0MECH(CHG)/10/2026-O/o SSE/Chg/1/HQ/NR
Date: 18.03.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 933/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Deepak S/o Mahavir R/o B-222, NSA Colony, Vishwas Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence FIR No. 344/15 u/s 33 Delhi Excise Act at P.S. Farsh Bazar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Deepak** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Deepak** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C. has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Deepak** accused of FIR No. 344/15 u/s 33 Delhi Excise Act at P.S. Farsh Bazar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **23.04.2026**

By Order: Sh. Akhil Malik,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02,
Room No. 38, Ground Floor,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/3584/SHD/2026

**ICICI Bank**

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	M/s. Dass Sales, Shimul Garg, Saurabh Garg, Shashi Garg, S/o Late Sh. Rajinder Prasad Garg, A/C No-43330500337, House No-B-26, Ashok Vihar, Opposite Post Office, Phase-I, North West Delhi, Delhi 110052	Property Bearing Shop No.25 on Ground Floor Without Roof Rights, Built on Leasehold Land Measuring Area- 12.45 Sq. Mtrs. Situated At Khurshid Market, Sadar Bazar, Central Delhi, Delhi- 110006, Admeasuring An Area of 12.45 Sq. Mtrs., North: Other Shop No.26 South: Other Shop No.24 East: Other Shop No.42, West: Gali	19-01-2026 Rs. 47,51,845.41/-	03-11-2025
2.	Manish Kherra S/o Late Sh. Lachaman Das Kherra, Vimla Kherra, A/C No-433305000672, House No. DP-205, Third Floor, Block- DP, Pitampura, Maurya Enclave, Shalimar Bagh, Saraswati Vihar, North West Delhi, Delhi- 110088	Residential Property Bearing Property No.205, Entire Third Floor With its Roof/ Terrace Rights, Block-DP, Built on Land Measuring 144.00 Sq. Mtrs., Situated In The Layout Plan of Pitampura Residential Scheme, Presently Known As Maurya Enclave, Pitampura, Delhi- 110088, North: Service Lane South: Plot No.204 East: Lane 4.5 Mtr Wide, West: Road 13.5 Mtr Wide	19-02-2026 Rs. 1,93,79,566.25/-	11-01-2026
3.	M/s. Jaspriya Enterprises, Sukhpreet Singh Alias Sukhpreet Singh Chawla, Sukhpreet Singh Chawla, Paramejeet Kaur Chawla, Represented By Proprietor Sukhpreet Singh Chawla, A/C No.033305051885, 2308/13, Gali Sapna Market, Hinga Beg Tilak Bazar North Delhi- 110006	Residential Property Entire Ground Floor (Without Roof Rights) of Freehold Built-up Property Bearing No.112, Block-A Pocket G-2, Sector 16, Area Measuring 48.00 Sq. Mtrs, Situated In The Layout Plan of Rohini Residential Scheme, Delhi- 110089, North: As Per Sale Deed South: As Per Sale Deed East: As Per Sale Deed West: As Per Sale Deed	10-02-2026 Rs. 15,14,273/-	10-12-2025
4.	M/s. Dsdna Engineers And Industries Private Limited, Mahesh Chander Sharma Alias Mahesh Chandra Sharma, Ravi Sharma, Sharin Sharma, Amit Sharma, Shalini Sharma, Meenakshi Agarwal, Simran Gour, Manish Kaushal, Shakuntla Sharma-Deceased (Through Its Legal Heirs), Represented By Directors Shalini Sharma, Ravi Sharma, Meenakshi Agarwal, Simran Gour & Manisha Kaushal, A/C No-057105002347 Flat No.704, Plot No.GH 12-A, Sector-21 C, Faridabad Haryana Faridabad- 121001	Address-1: Residential Property Bearing Flat No.704 On Seventh Floor (Consisting Of Three Bed Rooms, One Kitchen, One Store Room, Three Toilets, Five Balconies, Drawing-cum Dinning Room & Common Car Parking Area In The Stilt), Type-A, Measuring Area 99.80 Sq. Mtrs Approx. In The Prem Co-operative Group Housing Society Ltd., Situated At Plot No. Gh-12A, Sector-21C, Part-II, Faridabad, Haryana, 110077, Admeasuring An Area- 99.80 Sq. Mtrs Approx, North: Road South: Road East: Plot No, GH-14 West: R.E. N. H. Address- 2: Independent Residential Floor Bearing No. Aq1-06-GF, On Ground Floor, Block-AQ, Having Super Built-up Area Of 127.276 Sq. Mtrs (1370.00 Sq. Feet) Constructed Over A Plot Measuring 229.933 Sq. Mtrs (275.00 Sq. Yrds), Situated At Park-81, Sector-81, In Residential Colony Known As "Parklands", Folling Under Revenue Estate Of Villages Budena & Prahaladpur, Tehsil & District Faridabad, Haryana, 121001, Admeasuring An Area- Super Built-up Area Of 127.276 Sq. Mtrs (1370.00 Sq. Feet) & Plot Measuring 229.933 Sq. Mtrs (275.00 Sq. Yrds), North: As Per Conveyance Deed South: As Per Conveyance Deed East: As Per Conveyance Deed West: As Per Conveyance Deed	10-02-2026 Rs. 30,58,736.92/-	18-12-2025

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower/s and/or guarantor/s (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: March 20, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr
Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

No.-: JHS/W/T/Tender General/53 Date:- 18.03.2026

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-E-2026-53, **Description of work:** Jhansi **Division:-** Provision of Yatri shed, waiting hall, retiring room, ticket checking room & RPF room at Dariyaganj (DAYG) station.

Approx Cost : ₹ 1,85,88,491.00 **Earnest Money:** ₹ 3,71,800.00

Date of closing Tender : 13.04.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion /period from issue acceptance letter: 12 Months

• Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 13.04.2026 • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in 615/26 (MG)

 @CPNCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Inderjit Singh Sole Proprietor of M/s Jeet Electricals Office at: NE-119A, Gali No. 4, Vishnu Garden, New Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC No. 3902/2022 U/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Rajouri Garden, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Inderjit Singh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Inderjit Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Inderjit Singh** of case **CC No. 3902/2022 U/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Rajouri Garden, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.06.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Anshul Singhal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Room No. 268
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/3526/WD/2026 (Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice

Invitation of tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

N.I.T. No. : 37/(A-B)/25-26/WE

Name of work with its location:

(A) Provision of wooden flooring, false ceiling, tiles, doors, painting etc in rooms/ halls at 4th and 5th floor in Rail Bhawan and Renewal of certification (Indian Green Building Council Gold Rating) of Rail Bhawan Building, New Delhi in the section of SSE/VRB under ADEN/E-III.

(B) Special repair of camp offices of Ministers & repair to road of Tilak Bridge, College Lane Railway Colony under Jurisdiction of ADEN/E-III.

Approx. Cost of work : (A) Rs. 3,66,54,174.97, (B) Rs. 2,79,99,966.44

EMD amount : (A) Rs. 7,33,000.00, (B) Rs. 5,60,000.00

Completion period of work : (A) 08 Months, (B) 06 Months

Date and Time for submission of tender and opening of tender : Closing date of tender on 14.04.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Website particular notice board location complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc. : Above tender available on website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

No.: 128-W/269/O.E./T/NITNo. 37(A-B)/25-26/WE Dated: 17.03.2026 937/2026

**தமிழ்நாடு மத்தியப் பல்கலைக்கழகம்**
तमिलनाडु केंद्रीय विश्वविद्यालय
Central Institute of Technology (Tamil Nadu)
(Established by an Act of Parliament, 2009)
Neelakudi, Thiruvaur Tamil Nadu

தென்மேல் அறிவியல் / निविदा सूचना / Tender Notice

1. Supply and Installation of Laboratory Instrument High Speed Spinning Disk Confocal Super Resolution Microscope for Department of Biotechnology at CUTN, Thiruvaur.

2. Supply and Installation of UAV-Based LIDAR and Multispectral Scanning System for Department of Geography at CUTN, Thiruvaur.

3. Supply and Installation of Laboratory Instrument Field Emission Scanning Electron Microscope with EDS System for Department of Materials Science at CUTN, Thiruvaur.

4. Supply and Installation of Laboratory Instrument, High Resolution Mass Spectrometer with NANO -LC / UHPLC for Proteomics Metabolomics and Lipidomic Applications- 01 No and Triple Quad GC*GC/MSMS for Volatile, Pesticides, Metabolomics Application and Other Academic Chemistry Applications - 01 No. for Department of Horticulture at CUTN, Thiruvaur.

1. tender Ref. No.:
1. CUTN/PUR/2025-26/28 dt.13.03.2026
2. CUTN/PUR/2025-26/29 dt.13.03.2026
3. CUTN/PUR/2025-26/30 dt.13.03.2026
4. CUTN/PUR/2025-26/32 dt.13.03.2026

Please see the CUTN website <https://cutn.ac.in/tenders>

குறிப்பு / टिप्पणी / Note:
மேலும் விவரங்களுக்கு CUTN இணையத்தளம் மற்றும் CPP போர்ட் பார்க்கவும்.
अधिक जानकारी के लिए कृपया तकेबि की वेबसाइट www.cutn.ac.in और सीपीपी पोर्टल देखें।
For more details, please see the CUTN website www.cutn.ac.in and CPP portal.

cbc 21299/12/0024/2526 பத்திரம் கட்டுவதற்கு REGISTRAR

**Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd. (Arcil)**
Acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts
Arcil office : The Ruby, 10th floor, 29, Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West), Mumbai - 400 028.
Website : <https://auction.arcil.co.in>; CIN - U68999MH2002PLC134884

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR SALE THROUGH ONLINE E-AUCTION IN EXERCISE OF THE POWERS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (SARFAESI ACT) READ WITH RULES 6, 8 & 9 OF SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and to the Borrower (s) / Guarantor (s) / Mortgagee (s), in particular, that the below described immovable property/ies mortgaged / charged to the Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Limited, acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts ("ARCIL") (pursuant to the assignment of financial asset vide registered Assignment Agreements), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", "Whatever there is" and "Without recourse basis" by way of online e - auction, for recovery of outstanding dues of together with further interest, charges and costs etc., as detailed below in terms of the provisions of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("Act") read with Rules 6, 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 ("Rules").

Name of the Borrower / Co - Borrower / s / Guarantor / s / Mortgagee / s	LAN No. & Selling Bank	Trust Name	Outstanding Amount As Per SARFAESI Notice Dated 22.12.2021 Respectively	Possession Type and Date	Date Of Inspection	Type of Property and Area	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	Reserve Price	Date & Time of E-Auction
Borrower : 1. VIJAY KUMAR 2. SANGEETA	Loan Account No. HLAPNOI00295607	Arcil - CPS - IV - Trust	Rs. 23,10,967.67/- (Rupees Twenty Three Lakh Ten Thousand Nine Hundred Sixty Seven and Paise Sixty Seven only) as on 20.12.2021 + further Interest thereon + Legal Expenses	Physical possession on 29.10.2025	Will be arranged on request	Freehold - 509 sq. ft. (super built - up area)	Rs. 2,93,500/- (Rupees Two Lakh Ninety Three Thousand Five Hundred only)	Rs. 29,35,000/- (Rupees Twenty Nine Lakh Thirty Five Thousand only)	On 07.04.2026 at 04:30 P.M.

Description of the Secured Asset being auctioned :
ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL OF PROPERTY BEARING NO. - 48 - A (SOUTHERN PART), HAVING COVERED AREA OF 47.25 SQ. MTRS. I.E., 508 SQ. FT. (AS PER SALE DEED), UPPER GROUND FLOOR, KHASRA, NO. - 162, WEST AZAD NAGAR, SHAHDARA, NEW DELHI, DELHI - 110032.

Pending Litigations known to ARCIL	Nil	Encumbrances / Dues known to ARCIL	Nil
Last Date for submission of Bid	Same day 2 hours before Auction	Bid Increment amount :	As mentioned in the BID document
Demand Draft to be made in name of :	ARCIL - CPS - IV - TRUST	Payable at par	
RTGS details	ARCIL - CPS - IV - TRUST, Trust Account No. - 57500001353101, HDFC Bank Limited, Branch : Kamla Mill, Mumbai, IFSC Code : HDFC0000542		
Name of Contact person & number	Sanjeev Godara - 0124-6910910; +91 70654 51024 (auctionhelpline@sammaancapital.com)		

Terms and Conditions :
1. The Auction Sale is being conducted through e-auction through the website <https://auction.arcil.co.in> and as per the Terms and Conditions of the Bid Document, and as per the procedure set out therein.
2. The Authorised Officer ("AO") / ARCIL shall not be held responsible for internet connectivity, network problems, system crash down, power failure etc.
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4. The successful purchaser / bidder shall bear any statutory duties, taxes, fees payable, applicable GST on the purchase consideration, stamp duty, registration fees, etc. that is required to be paid in order to get the secured asset conveyed / delivered in his / her / its favour as per the applicable law.
5. The intending bidders should make their own independent enquiries / due diligence regarding encumbrances, title of secured asset and claims / rights / dues affecting the secured assets, including statutory dues, etc., prior to submitting their bid. The auction advertisement does not constitute and will not constitute any commitment or any representation of ARCIL. The Authorized Officer of ARCIL shall not be responsible in any way for any third - party claims / rights / dues.
6. The particulars specified in the auction notice published in the newspaper have been stated to the best of the information of the undersigned; however undersigned shall not be responsible / liable for any error, misstatement or omission.
7. The Borrower / Guarantors / Mortgagees, who are liable for the said outstanding dues, shall treat this Sale Notice as a notice under Rules 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, about the holding of the above mentioned auction sale.
8. In the event, the auction scheduled hereinabove fails for any reason whatsoever, ARCIL has the right to sell the secured asset by any other methods under the provisions of Rule 8(5) of the Rules and the Act.

Place : NEW DELHI
Date : 12.03.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer
Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd.



ALIA RECALLS HER FIRST DAY ON 'KAPOOR & SONS'

Bhatt shared fun memories dancing with Sidharth Malhotra in the song 'Kar Gayi Chul'

Bollywood superstar Alia Bhatt turned nostalgic on March 18, as she looked back at the making of 'Kapoor & Sons'. The actress, who recalled her very first day of shoot on the 10th anniversary of the movie, shared memories from the sets and spoke about filming the popular song 'Kar Gayi Chul', which became a massive hit among youngsters.

Resharing the post originally shared by 'Dharma Productions' on their social media account, Alia wrote, "Soo many memories #10YearsOfKapoorandSons."

Recalling the moment, Alia, in the video, is heard saying, "I remember my first day of shoot for 'Kapoor and Sons' was for 'Kar Gayi Chul', which went on to become such a big hit. So, when you see me dancing in 'Kar Gayi Chul', I am actually just dancing."

"I am just having a great time. I don't think that was very performative. It was just me genuinely having a good time and it's also the vibe that Shakun created. I remember even when we went for our main outdoor to Coonoor, even though I had to shoot on and off, I just stayed on. I was just there for the entire schedule," she added.

Alia Bhatt made her Bollywood debut with 'Student of the Year' in 2012, directed



The film was released in 2016 and also featured Fawad Khan, Ratna Pathak Shah and others

by Karan Johar. Talking about 'Kapoor & Sons', the movie released in 2016 and featured an ensemble cast including Sidharth Malhotra, Fawad Khan, Rishi Kapoor, Ratna Pathak Shah and Rajat Kapoor. AGENCIES

Priyanka among 'Top 5 Oscar' attendees by EMV

The list also includes Pedro Pascal, Kylie Jenner, Anne Hathaway & others

Priyanka Chopra Jonas did more than just make heads turn on the red carpet. The actress, who was among the many stars on the Oscars red carpet, ranked among the top five most influential attendees at the 2026 Academy Awards.

According to data analytics platform 'Lefty.io', the actress was among the top five on the ranking list, based on 'Earned Media Value' (EMV). This is a metric used to measure the online impact and visibility generated by celebrities across digital platforms during major events.

Topping the list was actor and presenter for the evening, Pedro Pascal, with an EMV of USD 3.3 million, followed by Kylie Jenner, who attended the event just to support her boyfriend, Oscar-nominee Timothee Chalamet. She earned an EMV of USD 3.1 million. Anne Hathaway, also a presenter for the evening, secured the third spot with USD 2.7 million.

The list is used to measure the online impact and visibility generated by celebrities across digital platforms during major events



Priyanka, who attended the ceremony as a presenter, ranked fourth with an EMV of approximately USD 2.2 million. The actress stunned on the red carpet in a white number with feather detailing. She attended the ceremony with her hubby, Nick Jonas, by her side.

Rounding out the top five was Zoe Saldana, last year's 'Best Supporting Actress' winner, with an EMV of USD 1 million.

At the Oscars, Priyanka presented the Academy Award for 'Best Foreign Film'. The award eventually went to 'Sentimental Value'.

Besides marking her presence at

the Oscars, Priyanka was also a regular at Hollywood's pre-Oscar parties and fashion shows. The star also turned presenter for the Golden Globe Awards, held early this year.

On the work front, Priyanka will soon head over to Antarctica to resume shooting for director SS Rajamouli's next 'Varanasi'. The team will reportedly be among the first few film crews to shoot at the Ross ice shelf. The film that still has months of shooting ahead of it, before it hits theatres in 2027. AGENCIES

NATIONAL INDIAN FILM FESTIVAL OF AUSTRALIA

'Boong' opens the film festival

Manipuri film 'Boong', the first Indian film to win a BAFTA award, opened the second edition of the National Indian Film Festival of Australia (NIFFA), which, the organisers said, is one of the largest celebrations of Indian cinema outside India.

The festival, running until July 5, will screen more than 32 films across 18 Indian languages in 14 cities, with all titles receiving their Australian premieres. The launch event on Tuesday was hosted by the Mayor of the City of Greater Geelong in collaboration with the Geelong Waterfront Film Foundation.

Veteran actor Anupam Kher, known internationally for his roles in 'Bend It Like Beckham', 'Silver Linings Playbook' and 'The Big Sick', will receive the festival's International Indian Cinema



Icon Award.

Kher said Australia held a very special place in his heart. "Festivals like this play an important role in building cultural bridges and allowing cinema to travel across borders, languages and communities," he added.

The actor's new directorial venture, 'Tanvi the Great', inspired by his 14-year-old autistic niece, will also screen

as part of NIFFA's new 'Able + Diverse' initiative, which focuses on representation of disability and diversity in cinema.

The festival will tour all major Australian capitals, including Sydney, Melbourne, Brisbane and Perth, and extend to regional centres including Broken Hill and Alice Springs.

The film festival will run until July 5

Filmmakers Anubhav Sinha and Leena Yadav will be honoured with the Nishtha (Dedication) Award for their contributions to mainstream and socially conscious cinema.

A focus on Punjabi cinema, presented in partnership with 'PTC Network', will culminate in the announcement of a three-

film India-Australia co-production initiative. 'PTC Network' CEO Rajeev Shinde will lead an industry delegation to Australia for the occasion.

The festival has secured institutional partnerships with the Western Australia Museum Boola Bardip, the Museum and Art Gallery of the Northern Territory, the State Library of Western Australia, Araluen Arts Centre and the Australia India Business Council, among others, a release said here. It also has the backing of 'Dendy Cinemas', 'Reading Cinemas' and 'SBS'.

Festival director Anupam Sharma said NIFFA had evolved beyond a film showcase. "NIFFA is no longer just a festival, it has become a national platform for conversations around cinema, culture, community and commerce," he said. PFI

A RANGE OF INDIAN MUSICAL TRADITIONS

'Coke Studio Bharat' returns with S4

'Coke Studio Bharat' is back with its fourth season, bringing together veterans such as Rekha Bhardwaj and Mame Khan alongside emerging voices including Faheem Abdullah and Aditya Rikhari, in a lineup that spans folk, Sufi, devotional and contemporary sounds from across the country.

The lineup also includes artists like Kulthe Khan, Arsalan Nizami, Madhur Sharma, Ashok Maskeen, Vaibhav Pani, Mohammad Faiz, Ravator, Khwaab and Utpal Udit.

The season draws from a wide range of Indian musical traditions - Rajasthani folk, Kashmiri narrative forms, Banaras-rooted accounts, Sufi lineage from Punjab - while also making room for contemporary takes on personal storytelling and modern love, the organisers said.

"Every generation rediscovers its roots in its own way. 'Coke Studio Bharat' provides a space where that rediscovery



The lineup features Rekha Bhardwaj, Faheem Abdullah, Aditya Rikhari, Kulthe Khan and many others

happens through collaboration. Season 4 is about preserving the spirit of tradition while allowing it to breathe in a new context," said Bhardwaj. Rikhari said the platform

storytelling to a national platform," he said.

Season 3 had delivered chart-topping tracks, including 'Arz Kiya Hai', a modern reinterpretation of India's poetry culture that topped Indian music charts and the festival-ready 'Holi Aayi Re'. Season 4 is expected to go deeper into India's local musical terrains, with the first track set to drop shortly.

Shantanu Gangane, IMX Lead at Coca-Cola India and Southwest Asia, said the platform had consistently demonstrated the power of regional languages, traditional instruments and untold stories at scale. "Over the last three seasons, we've seen a powerful narrative of regional languages, traditional instruments and untold stories being presented at scale. Season 4 accelerates that approach and showcases culture and music from the heartlands at a national and global stage," he added. PFI

AS DEEP AS THE GRAVE

Val's AI version to posthumously appear in the film

A year after the actor's death, a generative AI version of Val Kilmer will co-star in an independent film, in one of the boldest uses yet of artificial intelligence in moviemaking.

'First Line Films' announced that Kilmer has posthumously joined the cast of a film titled 'As Deep as the Grave'. The producers stated that, before his death, Kilmer had signed on to perform in the movie but was unable to do so due to his health.

Kilmer's estate gave permission for his digital replication and is being compensated for it. Mercedes Kilmer, the actor's daughter, said the role resonated with her father. "He always looked at emerging technologies with optimism as a tool to expand the possibilities of storytelling. This spirit is something that we are all honouring within this specific film, of which he was an integral part," she said.

Kilmer died last April at the age of 65 from pneumonia. In 2014,

Kilmer was diagnosed with throat cancer and required two tracheostomies. After losing his natural speaking voice, Kilmer turned to an AI software company to digitally recreate his voice. In his final screen performance, 2022's 'Top Gun: Maverick', Kilmer's voice was digitally altered.

The use of artificial intelligence in filmmaking has been one of the most contentious topics in Hollywood in recent years. Lately, some have attempted to make greater inroads for AI-generated performance. The company 'Xicoia' last year launched the AI-concocted persona 'Tilly Norwood'; earlier this month, it debuted a music video. SAG-AFTRA, the actors' union, condemned Xicoia's 'AI actor',



Mercedes Kilmer, the actor's daughter, said the role resonated with her father

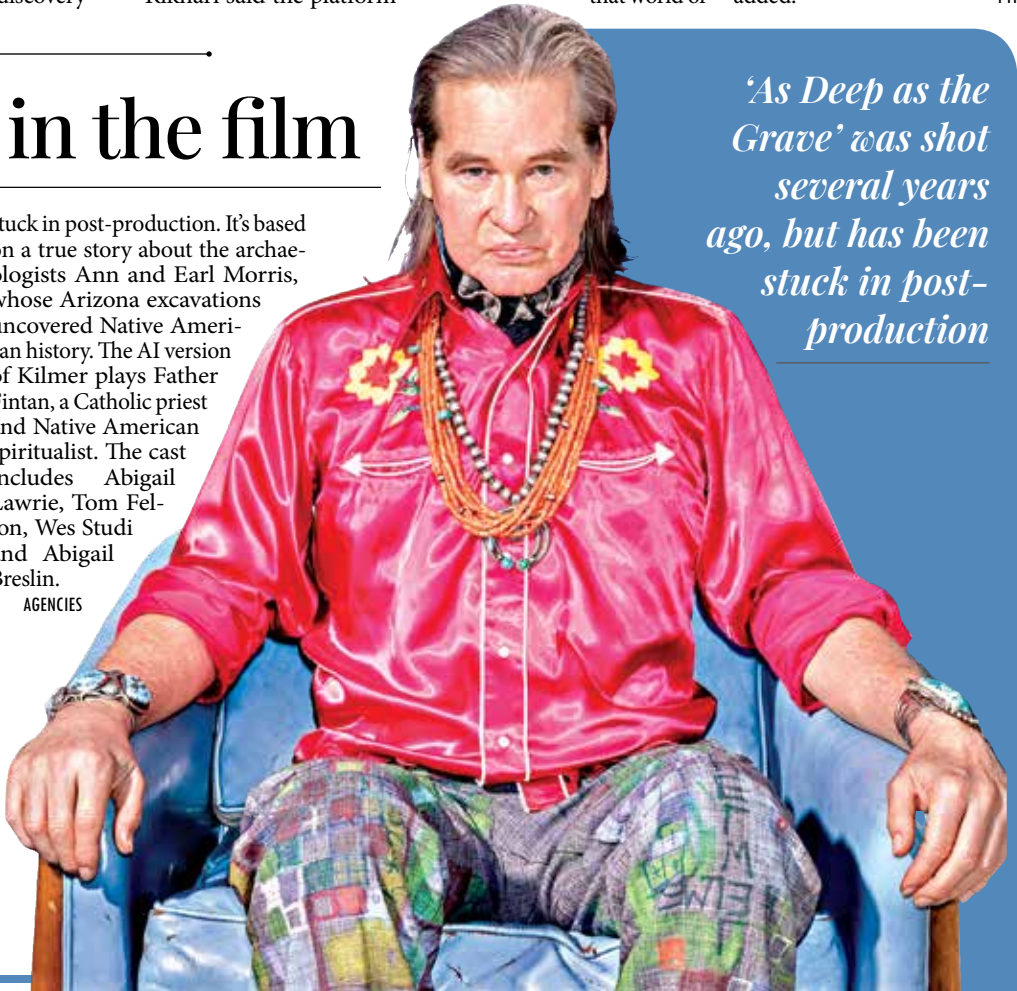
cas. "Consent not obtained before death must be obtained from an authorised representative or the union," reads its guidance. Representatives for SAG-

but it has regulations around other uses of the technology. Its rules stipulate that consent from performers must be given for the use of digital replication. "Consent not obtained before death must be obtained from an authorised representative or the union," reads its guidance. Representatives for SAG-

AFTRA didn't immediately respond to questions. In an email, writer-director Coerte Voorhees and producer John Voorhees said SAG guidelines were followed. "We believe we are serving as a demonstrator for how to do it ethically and correctly, especially in the case of working with a deceased actor's estate and family," they said.

'As Deep as the Grave', formerly titled 'Canyon of the Dead', was shot several years ago but has been

stuck in post-production. It's based on a true story about the archaeologists Ann and Earl Morris, whose Arizona excavations uncovered Native American history. The AI version of Kilmer plays Father Fintan, a Catholic priest and Native American spiritualist. The cast includes Abigail Lawrie, Tom Felton, Wes Studi and Abigail Breslin. AGENCIES



'As Deep as the Grave' was shot several years ago, but has been stuck in post-production